A dissertation in seven reels

AND MILES TO GO BEFORE I SLEEP

Cicatricial Mimesis, Sacrificial Dismemberment, and the Lazarus Complex in Robert Rodriguez and Quentin Tarantino's Grindhouse *(2007)*

MMXXVI

ABSTRACT

This dissertation advances a comprehensive reinterpretation of *Grindhouse* (2007), the composite double feature conceived by Robert Rodriguez and Quentin Tarantino—*Planet Terror*, *Death Proof*, and an interstitial apparatus of counterfeit trailers, bumpers, and advertisements by Rodriguez, Rob Zombie, Edgar Wright, Eli Roth, and, in Canadian exhibition, Jason Eisener—as the most rigorously self-theorizing artifact of American cinema's passage from photochemical to digital ontology. Against the paradigms that have absorbed the work into postmodern pastiche (Jameson), restorative nostalgia (Boym), or the cult economies of paracinematic taste (Sconce; Church), it argues that *Grindhouse* constitutes a sacrificial rite whose governing operation it names *cicatricial mimesis*: the manufacture, upon an image that has suffered nothing, of the scars of a history it never underwent, in order to claim membership in a community of the wounded.

The argument proceeds through five propositions. First, the counterfeit scratch, burn, and missing reel invert André Bazin's "mummy complex" into a *Lazarus complex*, in which the image must be seen to putrefy before it can be resurrected as cult object—an operation homologous to thanatosis, the death-feigning of animals, and to the professional thanatosis of the stunt performer. Second, the diptych is organized as a *sparagmos*, a deliberately dismembered body whose diegetic amputations (Cherry Darling's leg, Jungle Julia's leg, Abby's jar of testicles), formal lacunae (the missing reels), and industrial fate (its severance into separate features after a failed domestic release) are structurally isomorphic, recapitulating the Osirian, Dionysian, and Coyolxauhquian mythologies of dismemberment and prosthetic reassembly. Third, the two features enact a *double apocalypse*: *Planet Terror*, shot on high-definition video, stages apocalypse as catastrophe—the autoimmune collapse of a sovereign-military body consumed by the pharmakon it engineered, resolved in a Mesoamerican cosmogony of solar return at Tulum—while *Death Proof*, photographed on 35mm by Tarantino himself, stages apocalypse in its etymological sense of unveiling, stripping away its counterfeit patina to disclose the indexical, at-risk body of the stuntwoman Zoë Bell. Fourth, the diptych is a treatise on *immunity* in Roberto Esposito's sense, opposing the autoimmune state of exception (*Planet Terror*) and the asymmetrical immunitas of the "death proof" driver's seat (*Death Proof*) to a communitas of the exposed that figures, finally, the vanished congregation of the grindhouse auditorium. Fifth, the missing reels of both features, each of which excises precisely an erotic consummation, function as a *vanishing point*: the apophatic center of the diptych,

where eros is withdrawn from sight and transmuted into violence and, in *Planet Terror*, into the offscreen conception of a messianic child.

Synthesizing these propositions, the dissertation formulates a *Law of Conserved Damage*, according to which injury is neither created nor destroyed across the double feature but redistributed among four bodies—the filmic, the feminine, the sovereign-masculine, and the communal—and extends Ernst Kantorowicz's political theology into a doctrine of the film's two bodies. It concludes that *Grindhouse* anticipates both the faux-vintage visual culture of the following decade and the counterfactual historiography of Tarantino's subsequent cinema, and that its deepest philosophy is a theory of how images, like persons, enter community: by being wounded.

PROGRAM

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The woods are lovely, dark and deep,
But I have promises to keep,
And miles to go before I sleep,
And miles to go before I sleep.

Robert Frost, "Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening" (1923)

Lord, by this time he stinketh:
for he hath been dead four days.

John 11:39 (Authorized Version, 1611)

The dead have highways.

Clive Barker, "The Book of Blood" (1984)

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Introduction

THE COUNTERFEIT WOUND

0.1 The Object and Its Dismemberment

On 6 April 2007, Dimension Films released into American multiplexes a composite text of approximately one hundred and ninety minutes whose title named not a film but a regime of exhibition. *Grindhouse* proposed to reconstitute, within the architecture of the multiplex that had annihilated it, the experiential totality of the second-run exploitation double bill: two features, a slate of coming attractions, a regional restaurant advertisement, rating cards, "feature presentation" bumpers, and—crucially—the material evidence of use, in the form of scratched emulsion, splice jumps, chromatic fading, frame burns, and reels declared "missing." The program opens with Rodriguez's counterfeit trailer *Machete*; proceeds to *Planet Terror*, an infection-and-siege fantasy set in rural Texas; pauses for an interstitial cluster comprising Rob Zombie's *Werewolf Women of the SS*, Edgar Wright's *Don't*, and Eli Roth's *Thanksgiving*; and concludes with *Death Proof*, Tarantino's bisected slasher-cum-car-chase film, whose second half moves from Austin, Texas, to Lebanon, Tennessee. In some Canadian engagements, Jason Eisener's contest-winning *Hobo with a Shotgun* joined the interstitial slate.

The experiment failed in its domestic release, recovering a gross of roughly twenty-five million dollars against a production budget reported at more than twice that figure (both figures approximate); reports circulated that patrons departed after *Planet Terror* in the belief that the program had concluded. The composite was thereupon severed into two expanded features for international distribution—*Death Proof*, in an extended cut, having already competed for the Palme d'Or at Cannes in May 2007—and American home video at first reproduced the severance, the integral program reaching domestic home video only in 2010. The work therefore survives in two incompatible states: an integral body that few saw as intended, and a set of dispersed limbs that circulated widely.

This dissertation takes the composite as its object and treats the separate versions as limbs whose dispersal is itself constitutive of the work's meaning. Its methodological wager is that the industrial dismemberment of *Grindhouse* is not an accident external to its poetics but the completion of a figure the films had already drawn: a body cut apart, its missing parts replaced by prostheses, its integrity sacrificed as the price of a second life. The work's material history belongs to its text.

0.2 The State of the Question

Critical reception has distributed *Grindhouse* among three paradigms, each of which captures one stratum of the work while foreclosing the homologies between strata. The first is the paradigm of postmodern pastiche inaugurated by Fredric Jameson, for whom pastiche is "blank parody," the imitation of dead styles without satiric impulse, and for whom the "nostalgia film" substitutes the glossy connotation of pastness for historical understanding (Jameson 1991). Tarantino has

served as the exemplary instance of this diagnosis since *Pulp Fiction* (1994), and a film that manufactures pastness as a visual surface would appear to confirm it beyond dispute. The second is the paradigm of cult reception and the sociology of taste, descending from Pierre Bourdieu's analysis of distinction (1979) through Jeffrey Sconce's account of "paracinema" as a counter-canon constituted by the valorization of excess (Sconce 1995) to David Church's demonstration that the remembered grindhouse is substantially a construction of home-video fandom (Church 2015). Within this paradigm, *Grindhouse* is legible as the moment at which paracinephilic subcultural capital (Thornton 1995) was converted into a mainstream commodity. The third is feminist and psychoanalytic, organized around Laura Mulvey's theory of the male gaze (1975), Carol J. Clover's anatomy of the slasher and rape-revenge film (1992), Barbara Creed's monstrous-feminine (1993), and Linda Williams's "body genres" (1991); debate here has concentrated on whether *Death Proof*'s revenge reallocates or rehearses the gaze it inherits, and whether *Planet Terror*'s armed heroine is emancipatory figure or fetish. A fourth paradigm—the ontology of the digital image elaborated by D. N. Rodowick (2007), Philip Rosen (2001), Mary Ann Doane (2002), and Lev Manovich (2001)—has scarcely been brought to bear on the work, although its two features were produced on opposite sides of the photochemical-digital divide.

Each paradigm is correct within its stratum and insufficient beyond it. The pastiche paradigm cannot explain why the counterfeit damage is distributed with narrative precision rather than applied uniformly as stylistic varnish. The cult paradigm cannot explain why the diegeses—their amputations, contagions, and crashes—reproduce at the level of story the very operations performed upon the image. The feminist paradigm, attentive to bodies within the frame, has not attended to the body of the frame, and so misses the structural exchange by which wounds migrate between the female body and the filmic body. The digital paradigm has not recognized that *Grindhouse* stages a confrontation between Rodriguez's digital and Tarantino's photochemical practices, homogenized under a shared counterfeit patina and then differentiated again by the progressive cleansing of *Death Proof*'s second half. Richard Dyer's rehabilitation of pastiche as a means by which audiences may feel their way into historical sensibilities (Dyer 2007) approaches the present argument but stops short of it, because it treats pastiche as an affective technique rather than a sacrificial structure.

0.3 Method: Pathosformeln and the Discipline of Analogy

The method adopted here is comparative and morphological. Its patron is Aby Warburg, whose concept of the *Pathosformel*—the recurrent gestural formula through which antiquity's charged expressions of passion survive into later art, the *Nachleben der Antike*—and whose unfinished *Mnemosyne Atlas* (1924–29) model an analysis in which images are read through kinship with remote ances-

tors rather than through documented influence alone. *Grindhouse* is approached as a Mnemosyne Atlas of exploitation cinema: a panel on which the maenad, the dismembered god, the avenging collective, the psychopomp, and the wounded king reappear in the costume of the drive-in. To this Warburgian orientation are joined Claude Lévi-Strauss's structural analysis of myth, with its isolation of the mytheme and its account of mythic thought as *bricolage* (1955; 1962), Vladimir Propp's morphology of narrative functions (1928), Clifford Geertz's practice of thick description (1973), and a sustained engagement with political theology (Schmitt, Kantorowicz, Agamben, Esposito), material media theory (Benjamin, Bazin, Barthes, McLuhan, Virilio), and psychoanalysis (Freud, Lacan, Kristeva).

Comparative method invites what Samuel Sandmel, warning scholars of religion, called "parallelomania": the accumulation of resemblances mistaken for derivation (Sandmel 1962). Three criteria discipline the analogies proposed below. A comparison must exhibit *formal homology*, a shared structure of relations rather than a shared motif. It must possess *textual anchorage*, a specific feature of the film—a name, a cut, a casting decision, a line of dialogue, a setting—that activates the analogue. And it must yield *productive surplus*, disclosing something that would otherwise remain invisible. No claim is made that Rodriguez or Tarantino intended the mythological correspondences adduced; the claim is that their films, assembled from the sediment of a popular culture that is itself a reservoir of mythic form, organize that sediment according to structures whose oldest articulations are mythological.

0.4 Thesis

Grindhouse is neither pastiche nor homage nor nostalgia film but a sacrificial rite, whose governing operation is *cicatricial mimesis* (from the Latin *cicatrix*, scar): the manufacture, upon an image that has suffered nothing, of the scars of a history it never underwent, in order to claim membership in a community of the wounded. A scar is neither a wound nor its absence. It is the legible surface of a depth that has closed; it testifies at once to injury and to survival; and, since Eurycleia recognized Odysseus by the mark of the boar's tusk, it has served as a token of identity. Cicatricial mimesis therefore differs from Jameson's pastiche in that it does not abolish depth in favor of surface. It converts depth into surface while preserving its referral to an event.

Five propositions articulate the thesis. The first, the *Lazarus complex*, holds that the counterfeit damage inverts Bazin's mummy complex: where the photographic image was born of the desire to embalm the body against decay, the distressed digital image must be seen to rot before it can be raised as cult object. The second, *sparagmos*, holds that the double feature is constructed as a dismembered body whose diegetic, formal, and industrial mutilations are isomorphic. The third, the *double apocalypse*, holds that *Planet Terror* and *Death Proof*

stage, respectively, apocalypse as catastrophe and apocalypse as revelation, and that this opposition maps onto the opposition between digital simulation and photochemical index. The fourth, *immunity*, holds that the diptych dramatizes the crisis of the immunitary paradigm—autoimmunity in *Planet Terror*, asymmetrical immunization in *Death Proof*—and answers it with communities of exposure. The fifth, the *vanishing point*, holds that the two missing reels, both of which excise erotic consummation, constitute the apophatic center of the work, where eros vanishes from view and returns as violence and generation. These propositions converge in a *Law of Conserved Damage*: across the program, injury is redistributed rather than abolished among four bodies, the filmic, the feminine, the sovereign-masculine, and the communal.

0.5 Plan of the Work

Chapter One reconstructs the archaeology of grindhouse exhibition, from classical exploitation and its moralizing "square-up" to the 42nd Street theaters, their redevelopment, and their posthumous reconstitution on home video, and situates the 2007 release within the conjuncture of the digital transition and the War on Terror. Chapter Two traces the genealogies of the two directors and reads their collaboration, through Marcel Mauss and Georges Bataille, as a potlatch. Chapter Three reads *Planet Terror* through the pharmakon, autoimmunity, the grotesque, and a Chicana-Mesoamerican mythography of dismemberment and solar return. Chapter Four reads *Death Proof* through immunitas, the myths of Psyche, Persephone, Pentheus, and the priest of Nemi, and the progressive revelation of the indexical body. Chapter Five treats the counterfeit trailers and liturgical apparatus as Borgesian *hrönir*, fictional objects that subsequently entered reality. Chapter Six assembles a comparative morphology of five mythemes across mythology, literature, and horror. Chapter Seven formalizes the theory of cicatricial mimesis, the Lazarus complex, the film's two bodies, and the Law of Conserved Damage, and confronts the objections the theory must survive.



Chapter One

ARCHAEOLOGY OF THE GRIND

1.1 Etymology and Topography

The word *grindhouse* carries a contested double etymology that is itself diagnostic. One derivation refers to the "grind" policy of continuous exhibition—programs running from morning into the small hours at minimal admission, the projector grinding without intermission—while another refers to the "bump and grind" of the burlesque houses whose buildings and audiences the exploitation theaters inherited. The two etymologies name the two economies the form would always couple: the mechanical economy of uninterrupted repetition and the bodily economy of erotic display. From its name forward, the grindhouse was a site where the machine and the body met under the sign of exhaustion.

Its emblematic topography was West 42nd Street between Seventh and Eighth Avenues—"the Deuce"—whose former legitimate theaters were converted to motion-picture houses from the Depression onward and which, by the 1970s, sustained the densest concentration of exploitation exhibition in the United States. Bill Landis and Michelle Clifford's chronicle of the street (2002) and Samuel R. Delany's *Times Square Red, Times Square Blue* (1999) offer complementary accounts: the former a connoisseur's archaeology of the programs, the latter a theory of the theaters as spaces of "contact," the unplanned interclass encounter Delany opposes to the instrumental "networking" of the redeveloped city. The redevelopment of Times Square in the 1990s, accelerated by New York's 1995 zoning restrictions on adult businesses, erased that space. Its most symbolically charged moment was the restoration of the New Amsterdam Theatre, once a grind house, by the Walt Disney Company, which reopened it in 1997. The grindhouse's topography thus ends in its conversion into a sanctuary of the family entertainment it had negated. *Grindhouse* was released a decade later, into theaters whose architecture descended from the corporate reconstruction that had displaced its ideal audience.

The grindhouse was never only metropolitan. The drive-ins and second-run houses of the American South and Southwest constituted a parallel circuit through which exploitation pictures traveled by regional distribution, and here the program's own geography acquires significance. *Death Proof* moves from Austin, Texas—the base of Rodriguez's Troublemaker Studios—to Lebanon, Tennessee, in the state of Tarantino's birth; *Planet Terror* ends in Mexico, the ancestral horizon of Rodriguez's family history. The double feature traces a cartography of its authors' origins, and its terminus lies across the border.

1.2 Classical Exploitation and the Square-Up

Eric Schaefer's history of "classical exploitation" (1999) establishes that the form, between 1919 and 1959, defined itself by forbidden subject matter—sex hygiene, venereal disease, narcotics, vice, nudity, childbirth—distributed outside the Production Code through states-rights circuits and roadshow engagements. Its con-

stitutive rhetorical device was the "square-up," a prefatory text or lecture justifying the spectacle as education and warning. Kroger Babb's *Mom and Dad* (1945), exhibited with live lecturers and the sale of hygiene pamphlets, perfected a structure in which the pleasure of looking was licensed by the alibi of instruction. The exploitation film was born as a hypocrisy, and its hypocrisy was its form: the forbidden shown under the sign of the warning.

The square-up has never disappeared. It survives in the rating card that precedes each feature of *Grindhouse*; it survives in the critical discourse that redeems exploitation as cultural history; and—as this dissertation must acknowledge—it survives in the academic monograph, the most elaborate square-up ever devised, which licenses the contemplation of severed legs and melting flesh by the alibi of theory. The present study does not exempt itself from this structure. It proposes instead to make the structure visible as one of the work's subjects.

The exploitation circuit also absorbed films the studios disowned. Tod Browning's *Freaks* (1932), repudiated by MGM, was acquired and road-shown by Dwain Esper under lurid alternative titles, passing from the studio canon to the margins, where its community of disabled performers, and their terrible revenge upon the able-bodied woman who betrays one of them, could circulate as attraction. *Freaks* bequeathed to the exploitation tradition both its fascination with the anomalous body and its counter-fantasy: the communitas of the marked, closing ranks against those who exploit them. That double inheritance reappears at the end of *Planet Terror*.

1.3 The Drive-In, the Gimmick, and the Fragmentation of the 1970s

The postwar decades transformed exploitation from a regime of forbidden topics into a regime of youth, speed, and sensation. The company Samuel Z. Arkoff and James H. Nicholson founded in 1954, which became American International Pictures, built its business on the double bill and the drive-in; Roger Corman's economy of rapid, low-cost production, memorialized in his autobiography (1990), trained a generation of directors in the conversion of scarcity into style. William Castle's gimmicks—the buzzing seats of *The Tingler* (1959), the skeleton flown over the audience during *House on Haunted Hill* (1959)—addressed the spectator's body directly, prefiguring *Grindhouse*'s address to the spectator through the material condition of the print. Herschell Gordon Lewis and David F. Friedman's *Blood Feast* (1963) inaugurated the gore film by making the opened body the explicit object of display.

The collapse of the Production Code and the institution of the MPAA rating system in November 1968 released the energies the Code had contained. *Night of the Living Dead* (1968), shown at children's matinees in the interval before the ratings took hold, demonstrated that the cheapest film could carry the heaviest historical charge and inaugurated the allegorical zombie *Planet Terror* would revive. The

1970s saw exploitation fragment into a proliferation of subgenres—blaxploitation (*Sweet Sweetback's Baadasssss Song*, *Shaft*, *Coffy*, *Foxy Brown*), martial arts after *Enter the Dragon* (1973), women-in-prison, Nazisploitation, the car-chase picture, rape-revenge, and the Italian imports (gialli, zombie films, cannibal films, poliziotteschi) that reached American screens under new titles. The double bill juxtaposed these incommensurable artifacts according to the contingencies of booking. Meaning emerged from adjacency: a kung fu picture beside a cannibal film produced a collision legible only to a spectator who sat through both. Sergei Eisenstein had theorized the "montage of attractions" (1923) as the aggressive juxtaposition of shocks calculated to produce intellectual and emotional effect; the grind program realized an involuntary montage of attractions at the scale of exhibition. *Grindhouse* restages that montage deliberately, and so converts accident into design.

The New Hollywood, meanwhile, absorbed exploitation's methods. *Jaws* (1975), with its saturation release and national television advertising, applied exploitation's distribution logic to a studio production, and the blockbuster that followed was structurally exploitation's apotheosis. *Grindhouse* is therefore not the return of the margin to the center but the center's attempt to return to its own repressed origin: a prodigal blockbuster dressed in the rags of its ancestors.

1.4 Taste and the Inversion of Value

Bourdieu's *Distinction* opposed the "pure gaze" of legitimate culture, which privileges form over function, to a popular aesthetic that demands participation, sensation, and use. The cinephilic valorization of exploitation inverted this opposition by applying the pure gaze to precisely the objects the popular aesthetic consumed: it found form in trash. Pauline Kael's "Trash, Art, and the Movies" (1969) gave the inversion its most influential American expression, arguing that the pleasures of vulgar entertainment are the medium's democratic foundation and that a critic incapable of enjoying great trash has little reason to care about movies at all. Manny Farber's "White Elephant Art vs. Termite Art" (1962) supplied its aesthetic metaphysics, opposing the bloated masterpiece to the unpretentious, burrowing work of the B-film, which eats its way through the boundaries of its assignment. By Farber's standard, *Grindhouse* presents a paradox: a white elephant—a star-laden event film budgeted beyond any exploitation picture's dreams—disguised as termite art.

Susan Sontag's "Notes on 'Camp'" (1964) distinguished naive camp, which fails in earnest, from deliberate camp, which knows itself and is, in her judgment, usually less satisfying. *Grindhouse* is deliberate camp of the most knowing kind, and the present argument must answer Sontag's verdict. Its answer is that *Grindhouse*'s knowingness is not ironic detachment but mourning: the self-consciousness of an elegy, which knows that what it imitates is dead. Sontag's

later essay "The Decay of Cinema" (1996) announced the death of cinephilia itself. *Grindhouse* converts the title of that essay into a visual effect. The decay of cinema becomes literal, applied to the surface of the image, and therefore available for resurrection.

Sconce's paracinema names the reading protocol through which fans transformed exploitation into a counter-canon, valorizing excess, incompetence, and stylistic deviance as resistance to legitimate taste. Sarah Thornton's concept of subcultural capital explains its economy: knowledge of obscure films functions as currency within the subculture. *Death Proof* dramatizes that economy within its diegesis, where cinephilic knowledge of *Vanishing Point* (1971) distinguishes the women who will survive from those who will not. The paracinephile has become producer; the subculture has written its own scripture.

1.5 Afterlife on Video

The grindhouse died twice: once in the theaters, displaced by home video in the 1980s, and once in the city, erased by redevelopment in the 1990s. Between the two deaths it acquired an afterlife on magnetic tape. The video store—Tarantino's Video Archives in Manhattan Beach is the most mythologized instance—became the posthumous grindhouse, a library in which the programs of the 1970s were preserved as rentals and recombined by the curatorial passions of clerks. In Britain, the moral panic over "video nasties," culminating in the Video Recordings Act 1984 and the Director of Public Prosecutions' list of prosecutable titles, conferred on banned exploitation films the aura of martyrdom. Prohibition produced relics.

Church shows that the grindhouse fans remember is largely a home-video construction, a nostalgia for a theatrical experience many devotees never had, mediated by the visible wear of transferred prints that boutique labels such as Something Weird Video and Grindhouse Releasing came to market as signs of authenticity. Barbara Klinger (2006) demonstrates how the home became the primary site of cult replay, with the collector's edition and the discourse of restoration as its rituals. The scratch, in this economy, had already become a fetish before Rodriguez and Tarantino counterfeited it. *Grindhouse* did not invent the sacrality of damage. It discovered it in the reliquary of home video and returned it to the theater.

1.6 The Conjuncture of 2007

Grindhouse appeared at the midpoint of American cinema's conversion to digital technology. The digital intermediate, which *O Brother, Where Art Thou?* (2000) had pioneered for an entire feature, had become routine; the Digital Cinema Initiatives specification of 2005 had fixed the terms of digital projection; within five years Ko-

dak would file for bankruptcy protection (January 2012), and the photochemical chain would contract toward a boutique practice. In this context, simulated celluloid damage is not retro styling. It is the visible mourning of a material substrate at the moment of its disappearance, staged by one director (Rodriguez) who had become among digital cinema's most prominent evangelists and another (Tarantino) who would become among celluloid's most prominent defenders.

The year belonged, too, to the War on Terror. The photographs from Abu Ghraib (2004) had made the documentary image of torture a mass-circulated commodity, and David Edelstein's coinage "torture porn" (2006) named a cycle of horror films—*Saw* (2004), Eli Roth's *Hostel* (2005)—whose realist spectacles of prolonged suffering critics read as symptomatic of that climate. *Grindhouse* answered the cycle obliquely. Its violence is not forensic but carnivalesque, not prolonged but explosive; its wounds are not documents of suffering but grotesque fountains, nearer to Bakhtin's festive body than to the evidentiary body of the torture photograph. Roth's presence in the interstitial program makes the contrast explicit: the auteur of torture porn returns as a clown of splatter.

Finally, the release itself staged a failure of liturgy. Opening on Easter weekend, the program asked an audience habituated to the single feature to remain for more than three hours and to recognize the intermission as a threshold rather than an ending. The reported walkouts after *Planet Terror* are, from the perspective of this study, the most eloquent reception document the work possesses: the congregation no longer knew the rite.

2

Chapter Two

GENEALOGIES OF THEFT

2.1 Tarantino: The Clerk as Auteur

Tarantino belongs to the first generation of filmmakers educated primarily by video rather than by film school or repertory cinema. His years as a clerk at Video Archives produced a cinephilia indifferent to the hierarchies of national cinema, genre, and prestige, in which a Hong Kong heroic-bloodshed film, a spaghetti western, and a blaxploitation picture shared adjacent shelves and could be consumed in a single evening. The intellectual ancestry of that cinephilia is nonetheless precise. Jean-Luc Godard dedicated *À bout de souffle* (1960) to Monogram Pictures, a Poverty Row studio, announcing that the B-picture could be the occasion of avant-garde art; Tarantino named his production company A Band Apart after Godard's *Bande à part* (1964). The critics of *Cahiers du cinéma*, following François Truffaut's polemic against the "tradition of quality" (1954), discovered authors among genre directors, and Andrew Sarris's American translation of the *politique des auteurs* (1962; 1968) canonized Samuel Fuller, Nicholas Ray, and Edgar G. Ulmer. From Kael, Tarantino inherited the sensual, anti-academic insistence on pleasure; from Sarris, the impulse to make canons. His work synthesizes the two positions that defined American film criticism in the 1960s: an auteurism of pleasure.

The dictum, variously attributed to D. W. Griffith and to Godard, that a film requires only a girl and a gun presides over the entire oeuvre, and *Grindhouse* takes it literally: in *Planet Terror* the girl and the gun fuse into one body. Tarantino's revenge cinema has a totemic ancestor in John Flynn's *Rolling Thunder* (1977), cowritten by Paul Schrader, in which a returning prisoner of war whose hand has been destroyed sharpens his prosthetic hook into an instrument of vengeance. Tarantino named his short-lived distribution label, Rolling Thunder Pictures, after the film, and through it released titles ranging from Jack Hill's *Switchblade Sisters* (1975) to Wong Kar-wai's *Chungking Express* (1994). The prosthetic avenger is inscribed in the very name under which Tarantino curated other people's films.

Tarantino has distinguished in interviews between a "realer-than-real" universe, inhabited by the characters of films such as *Pulp Fiction*, and a "movie-movie" universe comprising the films those characters would themselves go to see, such as *Kill Bill* and *From Dusk Till Dawn*. The figure who confirms *Death Proof*'s place in the latter is Texas Ranger Earl McGraw (Michael Parks), who is shot dead in the opening sequence of *From Dusk Till Dawn* (1996), returns intact in *Kill Bill: Volume 1* (2003), and appears in both features of *Grindhouse*. McGraw is the Lazarus of the shared universe: a lawman who keeps dying and returning, and who in each return can diagnose evil without being able to stop it.

Tarantino's oft-quoted boast that he steals from every film ever made invites a medieval comparison. Patrick Geary's *Furta Sacra* (1978) analyzed the narratives in which central-medieval communities justified the theft of relics from rival shrines: the translation of a saint's body was presented as consented to, even

desired, by the saint, whose power would have prevented an unwelcome theft. Tarantino's appropriations are narrated in the same idiom. The stolen film is said to be honored; its revival by theft is presented as the fulfillment of its own desire to be seen again. Pastiche, in this light, is *translatio*: the removal of relics from a neglected shrine to a thriving one.

2.2 Rodriguez: The Body as Studio

Rodriguez, born in San Antonio in 1968 to a Mexican-American family, narrated his origin in *Rebel Without a Crew* (1995), the production diary of *El Mariachi* (1992). The legend is well known: a feature shot in Ciudad Acuña, Coahuila, for roughly seven thousand dollars and subsequently acquired by Columbia. Less often considered is the mode of its financing. Rodriguez raised part of the budget by volunteering for a month-long clinical trial of an experimental drug at a research facility in Austin, and he wrote the screenplay while confined there as a test subject. His cinema was purchased with his body's submission to pharmacology; the filmmaker's body served as experimental host before it served as studio. This fact, rarely treated as more than anecdote, becomes in Chapter Three a key to the pharmacological imagination of *Planet Terror*.

The "Mariachi method" that followed—Rodriguez as writer, director, cinematographer, editor, composer, and visual-effects supervisor—made of the auteur a prosthetic assemblage, a single body extended through every instrument of production. Marshall McLuhan argued in *Understanding Media* (1964) that every technological extension of the body entails an "autoamputation" and a corresponding numbness, the narcosis of Narcissus before his own extended image. Rodriguez's career is a laboratory of such extensions. His conversion to high-definition digital production after witnessing George Lucas's work, from *Spy Kids 2* (2002) through *Once Upon a Time in Mexico* (2003) and *Sin City* (2005), made him a public advocate of digital filmmaking, and his resignation from the Directors Guild of America in order to share directorial credit with Frank Miller on *Sin City* made him a public adversary of guild orthodoxy.

Rodriguez's genre lineage is equally legible. From John Carpenter he took the synthesized score and the siege; from George A. Romero, the allegorical contagion; from Sam Raimi, the kinetic splatstick and the weaponized prosthesis, since Ash's chainsaw-hand in *Evil Dead II* (1987) is the most famous limb-weapon of the horror canon; from Sergio Leone, the mythic gunfighter of the Mexico trilogy; from Mexican popular cinema, the lucha libre fantasies of El Santo and the horror films of the 1950s through the 1970s. *From Dusk Till Dawn*, written by Tarantino from a story by Robert Kurtzman and directed by Rodriguez, condenses this inheritance into a founding image. The Gecko brothers flee toward "El Rey," a criminal sanctuary borrowed from the close of Jim Thompson's novel *The Getaway* (1958), where the promised refuge is revealed as a gilded hell. They stop at the Titty Twister, a

desert strip bar whose dancer, Santanico Pandemonium, takes her name from Gilberto Martínez Solares's *Satánico pandemonium* (1975) and performs with a serpent; and the film's final shot reveals that the bar crowns a buried Mesoamerican temple. Beneath the exploitation venue lies the sacrificial pyramid. This is Rodriguez's primal scene, and *Planet Terror* returns to it.

Rodriguez's position within Chicano cinema is distinctive. The scholarship of Chon A. Noriega (2000) and Rosa Linda Fregoso (1993) reconstructed a Chicano cinema grounded in documentary, social realism, and the politics of the movement; Frederick Luis Aldama (2014) reads Rodriguez as the author of a different practice, in which Mexican-American identity is articulated through genre, speed, and the appropriation of mainstream forms. Ethnicity in Rodriguez is not represented as a social problem but deployed as a cosmology: the border, the temple, the mariachi, the machete, and the dead.

2.3 The Potlatch: Gift, Rivalry, Expenditure

The collaboration had passed through several forms before *Grindhouse*: the anthology *Four Rooms* (1995), in which each directed a segment; *From Dusk Till Dawn*, which Tarantino wrote and acted in under Rodriguez's direction; and a pair of symbolic transactions in which Rodriguez scored *Kill Bill: Volume 2* (2004) for a fee of one dollar and Tarantino directed a sequence of *Sin City* for the same sum. Marcel Mauss's *The Gift* (1925) identified the three obligations of archaic exchange—to give, to receive, and to reciprocate—and described the potlatch of the Pacific Northwest as agonistic gift-giving in which prestige was won through lavish distribution and, at the extreme, the destruction of wealth. Georges Bataille generalized the potlatch into a theory of *dépense*, arguing in *The Accursed Share* (1949) that societies are defined less by production than by the sumptuary, unproductive consumption of their surplus.

Grindhouse is a potlatch. Two directors spend more than fifty million dollars to manufacture the appearance of poverty; the luxury good they produce is simulated cheapness. The double feature is also an *agon*, in which each half competes with the other within a shared frame—a duel staged as an exchange of gifts—and the exchange includes bodies. In *Planet Terror*, Rodriguez casts Tarantino as a soldier whose attempted sexual assault ends with his putrefying body melting before he can consummate it; in *Death Proof*, Tarantino casts *Planet Terror*'s heroine, Rose McGowan, as the first victim of the death-proof car. Each director sacrifices an emblem of the other's half. The commercial failure of the program completes the potlatch's logic, since the destruction of value is the potlatch's highest form of prestige. The work became sovereign, in Bataille's sense, by being useless.

The motif of sovereign uselessness is written into *Planet Terror* itself. Cherry Darling's running lament concerns her "useless talents," the catalogue of idle bodily virtuosities she cannot convert into a living. The apocalypse retroactively

converts them into the competences of a warrior. The film enacts in miniature the logic of the whole program: what is spent without purpose becomes, in catastrophe, the condition of survival.

2.4 The Guild of the Trailers

The interstitial program assembled a guild of genre artisans whose work defined the horror landscape of the period. Rob Zombie had directed *House of 1000 Corpses* (2003) and *The Devil's Rejects* (2005) and would release his *Halloween* later in 2007; Eli Roth had directed *Cabin Fever* (2002) and *Hostel*; Edgar Wright had translated American genre forms into British comedy in *Shaun of the Dead* (2004) and *Hot Fuzz* (2007). Each contributed a trailer that functions within the program as a guild's pageant in a medieval mystery cycle: a self-contained station in a larger liturgy, executed in the house style of its makers. Jason Eisener, a Canadian unknown whose *Hobo with a Shotgun* won a contest attached to the release, entered the guild from outside, completing the circuit by which the fan becomes artisan.



3

Chapter Three

PLANET TERROR

Pharmakon, Autoimmunity,
and the Prosthetic Sovereign

3.1 Morphology: Siege, Contagion, Carnival

Planet Terror grafts two of the most durable morphologies in American horror. The first is the infection narrative in which a military agent escapes into a civilian population: George A. Romero's *The Crazies* (1973), in which a bioweapon code-named Trixie contaminates a Pennsylvania town's water; Dan O'Bannon's *The Return of the Living Dead* (1985), in which a military chemical revives the dead; David Cronenberg's *Shivers* (1975) and *Rabid* (1977), in which experimental medicine breeds contagion; and Danny Boyle's *28 Days Later* (2002), whose "infected" are not undead but diseased. The second is the siege narrative descended from Howard Hawks's *Rio Bravo* (1959) through John Carpenter's *Assault on Precinct 13* (1976) and Romero's *Night of the Living Dead*, in which a heterogeneous group defending an enclosure becomes a provisional community. *Planet Terror* sets the graft in a rural Texas of barbecue joints, a county hospital, and a military installation, and plays it in the register of the splatstick comedy perfected by *Evil Dead II* and Peter Jackson's *Braindead* (1992), under a synthesizer score Rodriguez composed in open homage to Carpenter.

The film's governing theory of contagion is Antonin Artaud's. In "The Theater and the Plague," collected in *The Theater and Its Double* (1938), Artaud likened theater to plague: a communicative delirium that passes from body to body, exposes the latent cruelty of a social order, and ends in death or in an extreme purification. *Planet Terror* literalizes the metaphor. It is a plague film designed to be caught.

The opening image condenses the film's poetics. Cherry Darling (Rose McGowan) go-go dances beneath the main titles and weeps as she dances. Before any monster has appeared, the image fuses two of the three "body genres" Linda Williams identified as the cinema of bodily excess—melodrama, whose sign is tears, and pornography, whose sign is sexual display—on the threshold of the third, horror. *Planet Terror* begins at the point where the body genres converge.

3.2 The Pharmakon

Jacques Derrida's "Plato's Pharmacy" (1968) reads the Greek *pharmakon*, at once remedy and poison, as the undecidable term on which the *Phaedrus* founders: writing, offered as a cure for forgetfulness, is condemned as its cause. *Planet Terror* is organized around the pharmakon at every scale. The biochemical agent DC2, which turns its victims into pustular "sickos," is also the substance on which Lieutenant Muldoon (Bruce Willis) and his unit depend to arrest their own decomposition. Their poison is their cure; their protection is their disease. The chemist Abby (Naveen Andrews), who traffics in the gas, presides over a pharmacy of damnation.

The pharmakon is redoubled in Dr. Dakota Block (Marley Shelton), an anesthesiologist whose syringes of sedative are instruments of care. Her jealous husband, Dr. William Block (Josh Brolin), turns those instruments against her, injecting her

hands with her own anesthetic, so that for much of the film the physician who administers anaesthesia is anaesthetized in the organs of her craft. Susan Buck-Morss argued in "Aesthetics and Anaesthetics" (1992) that modernity's regime of shock produces a protective numbing of the sensorium, so that aesthetics—once the discourse of sensory perception—becomes anaesthetics. Dakota's dead hands allegorize the spectatorial condition of 2007: a sensorium numbed by the saturation of violent imagery, which *Grindhouse*'s shocks seek at once to exploit and to restore to feeling. They also literalize McLuhan's coupling of extension and narcosis: the medical technology that extends the physician's power numbs the hand that wields it.

The film's pharmacological imagination returns to the origin of Rodriguez's cinema. The director who bought his first feature by renting his body to a clinical trial has made a film in which an experimental agent escapes the laboratory and transforms bodies across a county. *Planet Terror* is the return of the repressed of its maker's mode of production: the body sold to pharmacology to purchase cinema reappears as a plague purchased by cinema. The clinical trial is the film's unconscious.

3.3 Autoimmunity and the Planetary Exception

Muldoon's unit has brought the plague home from war. In the film's most audacious anachronism, Muldoon claims that his men were exposed during the operation in which they killed Osama bin Laden. The film was released four years before bin Laden's death in May 2011, and its fantasy imagines that killing as a contaminating act whose consequences return to poison the homeland. The returning soldier as walking contagion has a genealogy in Bob Clark's *Deathdream* (1974), in which a son killed in Vietnam comes home as a corpse sustained by blood, and in *Rolling Thunder*'s veteran with the weaponized hook. In each case the war is not over there. It is carried home in the soldier's body.

Derrida's concept of autoimmunity, developed in the dialogues collected by Giovanna Borradori in *Philosophy in a Time of Terror* (2003) and in *Rogues* (2003), names the process by which an organism, or a political order, destroys its own protective mechanisms in the act of defending itself. *Planet Terror* stages autoimmunity at every level. At the national level, a weapon developed for security becomes the agent of domestic catastrophe. At the professional level, the physician's anesthetic disables the physician. At the familial level, the Blocks' young son dies by the pistol entrusted to him for his protection. At the corporeal level, the soldiers survive only by inhaling the substance that destroys them. Roberto Esposito's *Immunitas* (2002) shows that the immunitary paradigm of modern politics protects life by introducing into it a controlled dose of its negation, on the model of the vaccine. *Planet Terror* depicts that paradigm in terminal crisis, where the dose has become the disease.

The military installation to which the survivors are taken is a camp in Giorgio Agamben's sense (1995; 2003): a space of exception in which the infected are reduced to bare life, killable without the commission of homicide, their personhood annulled by the nickname "sickos." Achille Mbembe's account of necropolitics (2003), in which sovereignty is exercised as the power to dictate who may live and who must die, describes the quarantine regime the film imagines. The title completes the allegory. "Planet Terror" names the globalization of the War on Terror: terror has ceased to be an enemy and become a planetary condition, and the planet itself has become the theater of the exception. The double genitive is exact. It is the planet of terror and the terror of the planet.

3.4 Grotesque, Abject, Interstitial

Mikhail Bakhtin's *Rabelais and His World* (1965) described the grotesque body of carnival as open, protruding, and unfinished, a body that outgrows itself through its orifices and excrescences and whose degradations are also regenerations. The sickos of *Planet Terror* are grotesque bodies in this sense, erupting in pustules that burst with comic abundance, and the film's carnival laughter accompanies their dissolution. Julia Kristeva's theory of abjection (1980), which locates in the corpse the utmost threat to the boundary between self and other, explains the nausea the laughter manages. Mary Douglas's *Purity and Danger* (1966) defined dirt as matter out of place, and Noël Carroll's *The Philosophy of Horror* (1990) derived the monster's horror from its categorical interstitiality, its violation of the boundaries between living and dead, inside and outside, human and inhuman. The sickos are interstitial bodies: neither dead nor alive, neither patients nor monsters.

The film's erotics of putrefaction belongs to an older tradition. Charles Baudelaire's "Une Charogne" (1857) addresses the beloved before a rotting carcass and reminds her that she, too, will become one. *Planet Terror* repeatedly sets McGowan's stylized glamour against the decomposition of the bodies around her, so that beauty and rot share a single frame, as in the decadent poem.

Here the dissertation advances a claim developed in Chapter Seven. The sicko is the ontological self-portrait of the distressed digital image. A digital file does not decay as a print decays; it is, in principle, incorruptible. *Planet Terror*'s image, shot on high-definition video, is therefore an undead image wearing the costume of decay: its scratches and burns are pustules applied to a body that cannot rot. The film's zombies and the film's surface are isomorphic. Both simulate putrefaction in a body that will not die, and both make that simulation the condition of their appeal. The term proposed for this operation is *thanatomimesis*: the mimicry of one's own death.

3.5 The Castration Economy

Abby keeps a jar of testicles harvested from men who have crossed him. The jar is the film's most literal emblem of a castration economy that governs its treatment of masculinity. In the Arthurian romances that run from Chrétien de Troyes's *Perceval* (c. 1190) to Wolfram von Eschenbach's *Parzival*, the Fisher King suffers a wound in the thigh, which the tradition reads as genital, and his wound lays waste the land until the right question is asked; Jessie L. Weston's *From Ritual to Romance* (1920), and T. S. Eliot's *The Waste Land* (1922) after it, made the wounded king the emblem of a sterile modernity. *Planet Terror*'s infected county is a wasteland of wounded kings. Dr. Block, the jealous husband, decomposes; Muldoon, the soldier-hero, becomes a pustular addict; Tarantino's would-be rapist melts; the brothers Hague are reconciled only in death. The secret recipe for barbecue sauce that passes between the brothers at the deathbed is the film's profane Grail, a secret knowledge whose transmission requires a death.

The barbecue carries a darker inheritance. In Tobe Hooper's *The Texas Chain Saw Massacre* (1974), a roadside barbecue sells meat whose origin the film leaves to the viewer's nausea. *Planet Terror*'s Bone Shack stands in a carnal continuum running from the barbecue pit to anthropophagy, a continuum the sickos complete. The men of *Planet Terror* decay. Its women are re-membered.

3.6 Cherry Darling: From the Coatlicue State to the Prosthetic Sovereign

Cherry Darling's name is a palimpsest: the cherry of virginity and popular slang, the diminutive endearment of the stage name, the confection of the exploitation poster. Her ambition is to become a stand-up comedian, an aspiration the film answers with savage irony when it takes away her capacity to stand. Her opening tears place her, in the vocabulary of Gloria Anzaldúa's *Borderlands/La Frontera* (1987), in the "Coatlicue state": the paralysis, despair, and self-division that precede a breakthrough into new consciousness, named for the Mexica earth goddess of the serpent skirt and the necklace of hands and hearts.

The dancing woman of the exploitation tradition descends from Russ Meyer's homicidal go-go dancers in *Faster, Pussycat! Kill! Kill!* (1965) and from Santanico Pandemonium's serpent dance in *From Dusk Till Dawn*. In Warburg's terms she is a modern avatar of the *Ninfa*, the swift female figure in agitated drapery whose appearance in Ghirlandaio's frescoes Warburg traced to the maenads of antiquity: the Dionysian woman in motion, whose dance is the prelude to violence.

Cherry's leg is torn away by the infected. The amputation recalls the central image of Mexica cosmogony recovered in February 1978, when electrical workers in Mexico City uncovered the great stone of Coyolxauhqui at the foot of the Templo Mayor. The relief shows the moon goddess decapitated and dismembered, her limbs severed from her torso, after her defeat by her brother Huitzilopochtli at Coatepec. In *Light in the Dark/Luz en lo Oscuro* (2015), Anzaldúa made Coyolx-

auhqui the emblem of what she called the Coyolxauhqui imperative: the labor of reassembling a self fragmented by trauma, conquest, and division. *Planet Terror* follows that imperative to the letter. Cherry's dismemberment is the precondition of her re-membering.

The first prosthesis is an act of *bricolage* in Lévi-Strauss's sense: El Wray (Freddy Rodriguez) fits her stump with a wooden table leg, a fragment of domestic furniture improvised into a limb. The leg of the table, the site of commensality and the shared meal, becomes the leg of a woman; the communal becomes corporeal. The second prosthesis is an assault rifle fitted with a grenade launcher, and with it the dictum of the girl and the gun collapses into a single body. The genealogy of the image runs through *Rolling Thunder*'s hook, *Videodrome*'s fusion of flesh and pistol (1983), *Rabid*'s phallic stinger, *RoboCop*'s corporately reassembled policeman (1987), and Ash's chainsaw-hand, and it finds theoretical articulation in Donna Haraway's "A Cyborg Manifesto" (1985), which described cyborgs as the illegitimate offspring of militarism and patriarchal capitalism and observed that illegitimate offspring are often unfaithful to their origins. Cherry's leg is military issue turned against the military.

The deepest analogues are Greek and Irish. In Sophocles' *Philoctetes* (409 BCE), the hero is abandoned on Lemnos because of a festering, malodorous wound, yet he holds the bow of Heracles without which Troy cannot fall; Edmund Wilson's *The Wound and the Bow* (1941) made of this conjunction a theory of art, in which the artist's wound and power are inseparable. In Cherry, wound and bow are the same organ. In the Irish *Cath Maige Tuired*, Nuada, king of the Tuatha Dé Danann, loses his arm in battle and is fitted by the physician Dian Cécht with an arm of silver; because a blemished king may not rule, Nuada yields the kingship until his prosthesis is replaced with flesh. *Planet Terror* abolishes the law of the unblemished king. Its new sovereign rules because she is prosthetic.

The image must also be read against itself. Freud's theory of fetishism and Creed's analysis of the phallic woman identify in such figures a disavowal of castration rather than its overcoming: the armed woman whose prosthesis is a phallus may be the male imagination's consolation rather than female power. The prosthesis is fitted by El Wray and designed by Rodriguez; the emancipated body is authored by men. Disability studies sharpens the critique. David T. Mitchell and Sharon L. Snyder's *Narrative Prosthesis* (2000) shows how narratives lean on disability as a device of disruption and characterization—a crutch on which stories depend and which they then repair or erase—and Eli Clare's *Exile and Pride* (1999) criticizes the "supercrip," whose disability is redeemed only by superhuman capacity. Cherry is the apotheosis of the supercrip, and her amputation was achieved by digitally erasing an able-bodied actress's leg. This dissertation does not resolve the ambivalence. It registers it as constitutive, because ambivalence is the structure of the scar itself: at once the memory of a wound and the proof of its closure.

3.7 El Wray, El Rey: The Sacred King and the Missing Reel

El Wray's name sounds the Spanish *el rey*, the king; it also sounds Link Wray, whose instrumental "Rumble" (1958) was kept off some radio playlists for fear it would incite violence. His past is withheld throughout, his competence inexplicable, his authority mythic. He is the sacred king of James George Frazer's *The Golden Bough* (1890), whose life is bound to the fertility of the land and whose death must precede its renewal. In Plutarch's *On Isis and Osiris*, the murdered and dismembered Osiris is reassembled by Isis, who fashions a replica of the one member she cannot recover; Plutarch adds that the child Isis bore to the dead god, Harpocrates, came into the world untimely and weak in his lower limbs. El Wray dies in the climactic assault on the military base, and the community at Tulum is presided over by Cherry as a mother.

The child is conceived in the missing reel. As El Wray and Cherry begin to make love, the image burns in the projector gate, a card announces a missing reel, and the film resumes amid fire with its plot conspicuously advanced. The lacuna swallows the consummation and, by implication, the exposition of the hero's past the film had promised. The conception of the child who will inherit the new world occurs in the film's blind spot. The Gospel of Luke describes the Incarnation as an overshadowing: the power of the Highest, the angel tells Mary, shall overshadow her (Luke 1:35). The missing reel is an overshadowing. Where Tarantino's corresponding lacuna would be restored in his extended cut, Rodriguez's persists in his, a constitutive absence rather than a contingent one. The most generative event of *Planet Terror* is the one the film refuses to show.

3.8 Tulum: The Dawn Beyond the Wound

The survivors flee south. Frederick Jackson Turner's frontier thesis (1893) made the westward movement of settlement the engine of American character; the dominant migratory narrative of the late twentieth century ran northward across the Mexican border. *Planet Terror* reverses both. Anzaldúa described the border as *una herida abierta*, an open wound where the Third World grates against the first and bleeds. The film crosses the wound against the direction of its history, and its survivors become refugees in Mexico.

They settle among the ruins of Tulum, the walled Maya port on the Caribbean coast of Quintana Roo, whose older name is commonly given as Zamá, glossed as "dawn" for its orientation toward the rising sun, and whose temples include one dedicated to the Descending God, an inverted diving figure carved above its doorway. Rodriguez's cosmos thereby completes its diurnal cycle. *From Dusk Till Dawn* ended at the buried temple beneath the bar of the night; *Planet Terror* ends at the city of dawn. Mircea Eliade's *The Myth of the Eternal Return* (1949) describes the archaic regeneration of time through the cyclical repetition of cosmogony. The Old Norse *Völuspá* imagines that after Ragnarök a green earth will rise again from

the sea, and Snorri's *Gylfaginning* names the two humans, Líf and Lífþrasir, who will repopulate it. Tulum is the film's post-Ragnarök shore.

The final image of Cherry, armed, maternal, and facing east, recalls the woman of Revelation 12, clothed with the sun and with the moon under her feet, who bears a child destined to rule and flees from the dragon into a wilderness prepared for her. That apocalyptic woman is the iconographic source of the Virgin of Guadalupe, whose apparition at Tepeyac in 1531 Chicana thought has long read in relation to the Nahua mother-goddess Tonantzin and, through her, to Coatlicue. Chicana artists reclaimed the Guadalupana as an active body—Yolanda López's Guadalupe series of 1978 depicts the artist herself as a running Virgin in sneakers—and the essays Ana Castillo collected in *Goddess of the Americas* (1996) theorize that reclamation. Cherry's arc completes a Chicana-Mesoamerican mythography: from the Coatlicue state of the opening tears, through the Coyolxauhqui dismemberment, to the Guadalupana at the city of dawn.

Planet Terror belongs, finally, to a constellation of contemporaneous films by Mexican and Mexican-American directors that might be called the apocalyptic triptych of 2006–2007. Alfonso Cuarón's *Children of Men* (2006) follows a woman carrying the first child born in eighteen years toward a ship named *Tomorrow*. Guillermo del Toro's *Pan's Labyrinth* (2006) sets a girl against a fascist officer and opens to her, through her own blood, an underground kingdom. *Planet Terror* sets a woman and a child conceived offscreen against a militarized sovereign and brings them by the sea to a city of dawn. In all three, the future is carried in a woman's body and reached at the edge of the world. Rodriguez's version alone arms its utopia and locates it in Mexico. That location carries an irony the film cannot dissolve: Tulum is also a tourist destination, and an American community resettling there reenacts, even in apocalyptic inversion, the fantasy of Mexico as an available refuge. Aníbal Quijano's analysis of the coloniality of power (2000) names the structure the film inverts without escaping.

4

Chapter Four

DEATH PROOF

Immunitas, Psyche, and the Apocalypse of the Index

4.1 Morphology: A Diptych within the Diptych

Death Proof reproduces within itself the binary structure of the program. Its first half, set in Austin, follows a group of young women through an evening of talk and drink that ends in their deaths. Its second half, set fourteen months later in Lebanon, Tennessee, follows four other women, three of whom confront the same predator and kill him. The halves oppose massacre to revenge, a distressed image to a progressively cleansed one, the failure of law to the triumph of a collective. The film is a fractal of the double bill. Even its title sequence participates in the archaeology of exhibition: an alternate title, *Thunder Bolt*, is briefly glimpsed before a crudely spliced "Death Proof" card supplants it, mimicking the redistribution practice of retitling.

The film's dialogue has been the most frequent object of complaint. Its women talk at length—about men, sex, drugs, music, films, and cars—while the narrative waits. The longueurs can be reread as ritual delay. In *The Thousand and One Nights*, Scheherazade postpones her execution by narration; in Boccaccio's *Decameron* (c. 1353), seven young women and three young men withdraw from plague-stricken Florence to tell stories. *Grindhouse* recomposes the *Decameron*'s frame: the plague rages in the first feature, and the women talk in the second. Talk is the film's anti-thanatos, the speech by which life lengthens its detour toward death. Bakhtin's essay on the chronotope (1937–38) identified the road as the space-time of chance encounter, where the paths of strangers cross and fates are decided. *Death Proof* is a road film in Bakhtin's sense, and its bar, the Texas Chili Parlor, is the threshold where the encounter is arranged. Tarantino appears there as Warren, the bartender who pours the women's liquor. The auteur casts himself as the dispenser of intoxicants, the keeper of the pharmakon.

Roland Barthes observed in *The Pleasure of the Text* (1973) that readers practice *tmesis*, skipping descriptions to hasten toward the erotic or the dramatic. The missing reel is a tmesis imposed by the text, but its direction is inverted: it skips precisely what the impatient reader would never skip. It is an ascetic tmesis.

4.2 Stuntman Mike: The Scar, the Stunt, the Superannuated God

Stuntman Mike McKay (Kurt Russell) bears a scar that runs down his face. In the first chapter of *Mimesis* (1946), Erich Auerbach analyzed the episode in the nineteenth book of the *Odyssey* in which the nurse Eurycleia, washing the disguised hero's feet, recognizes him by the scar of a boar's tusk, and Homer interrupts the recognition to narrate the full history of the wound. The scar is the classical token of identity, the mark that permits anagnorisis. Mike's scar is his credential and his lure: it authenticates him as a survivor of real danger and invites the story he will tell. But the anagnorisis fails. The women do not recognize the television programs on which he worked. The god is forgotten.

The stunt performer's craft is a professional thanatosis, the art of feigning injury or death while surviving. The stuntman is the industry's sacrificial body, the one who takes the fall so that the star's image may remain intact, and the profession's history is punctuated by real deaths: H. B. Halicki, whose *Gone in 60 Seconds* (1974) Tarantino's women revere, died in 1989 during a stunt for its sequel. Richard Rush's *The Stunt Man* (1980) imagined a director-god who may be willing to sacrifice his stunt performers to his vision; Hal Needham's *Hooper* (1978) imagined the aging stuntman's final jump as a farewell to the profession's heroic age. Mike belongs to the twilight of the stunt-gods, superseded by digital effects. In Neil Gaiman's *American Gods* (2001), gods survive only as long as they are believed in; Mike is a minor deity of 1970s car culture whose worshippers have dwindled to the two women of the second half who still know *Vanishing Point*. They are his last believers, and they kill him.

Russell's star persona is a palimpsest the film exploits. A Disney juvenile of the 1960s, he became the emblematic heroic body of John Carpenter's cinema: Elvis Presley in the television film *Elvis* (1979), Snake Plissken in *Escape from New York* (1981), MacReady in *The Thing* (1982), Jack Burton in *Big Trouble in Little China* (1986). *Death Proof* repurposes the action hero of the 1980s as predator, revealing the genre's masculine ideal as threat.

J. G. Ballard's novel *Crash* (1973), adapted by David Cronenberg in 1996, created in Vaughan a scarred prophet of the automobile who stages and photographs collisions and dreams of dying in a crash with a film star. Mike is Vaughan's descendant. In the hospital after the first massacre, Texas Ranger Earl McGraw explains to his son that the collision was deliberate and that Mike's killing is a mode of sexual release, the car serving as instrument and the crash as consummation; he concedes that he cannot prove it. Paul Virilio's *The Original Accident* (2005) argued that every technology invents its own accident, the train its derailment and the ship its shipwreck. Mike's murders are designed accidents, indistinguishable before the law from the contingency they simulate.

In the opening chapter of *The Golden Bough*, Frazer describes the priest of the grove at Nemi, the *rex Nemorensis*, a runaway slave who holds his office by having killed his predecessor and who paces the sacred grove, sword in hand, awaiting his own murderer. Mike is a *rex Nemorensis* of stunt culture, the aging priest of a dying cult, and he is slain by his successor: Zoë Bell, a working stuntwoman playing herself.

4.3 The Death-Proof Seat: Immunitas and the Abduction of Persephone

The film's title names a technology of exemption. Mike explains to Pam, who accepts his offer of a ride home, that his reinforced stunt car is death-proof only for whoever occupies the driver's seat; the passenger side is unprotected. No cinematic image more exactly figures Esposito's *immunitas*. The Latin *munus* names a

gift, an office, and an obligation; *communitas* is the condition of those who share the munus, *immunitas* the condition of the one exempted from it. The road is a community of mortal exposure in which every driver shares the risk of every other. Mike's crime is the privatization of immunity. He exempts himself from the munus of mortality and transfers it to the passenger, who becomes, in Agamben's vocabulary, bare life.

Pam is played by Rose McGowan, and her entry into the black car recalls the abduction of Persephone in the Homeric *Hymn to Demeter*, where the lord of the dead bursts from the earth in his chariot and carries the maiden down. McGowan's double casting makes the allusion structural. In the order of the program she rises as Cherry in *Planet Terror* and descends as Pam in *Death Proof*: the double feature runs the cycle of Persephone in reverse, ascent before descent. In the grind houses that gave the program its name, exhibition was continuous and the program began again; the grind policy enacted an eternal return in which Pam's death is followed, at the next screening, by Cherry's rise.

4.4 Butterfly: Psyche, the Siren, and the Withheld Dance

Jungle Julia (Sydney Tamiia Poitier), a disc jockey in Austin, announces on air that whoever buys her friend Arlene a drink, calls her "Butterfly," and recites the opening of a poem will receive a lap dance. The poem is Frost's "Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening." The disc jockey is an oracle. In *Vanishing Point*, the blind disc jockey Super Soul guides the fugitive driver Kowalski over the airwaves, a Tiresias of the radio; in *Death Proof*, Jungle Julia's broadcast becomes the instrument of fate. Like the oracle of Thebes, she speaks a sentence whose meaning will be fulfilled against her.

"Butterfly" is not an arbitrary nickname. The Greek *psychē* names both the soul and the butterfly, and ancient iconography represented the soul in that form. Mike, the psychopomp, claims the soul by password. The governing myth is Apuleius's tale of Cupid and Psyche in the *Metamorphoses*: Psyche is visited in darkness by a lover she is forbidden to see, and when she lights a lamp to look at him, he flees. In the *Grindhouse* version of *Death Proof*, the lap dance is replaced by a missing-reel card. The prohibition on sight is enforced by the text; Psyche's lamp is extinguished. The extended cut would restore the dance, set to the Coasters' "Down in Mexico" (1956), a song whose title gestures across the intermission toward *Planet Terror*'s destination.

Frost's poem has long been read as a meditation on the attraction of death. The woods are lovely, dark, and deep; the speaker is drawn to stop in them; only his promises call him on. Its final line is repeated, and the repetition transforms it: the first "miles to go before I sleep" is literal, the second metaphysical, and sleep becomes death. In Mike's mouth the poem is a Siren's song, the call of the twelfth book of the *Odyssey* to stop and rest forever. Freud's *Beyond the Pleasure Principle*

(1920) proposed that the organism seeks to return to the inorganic but wishes to die only in its own fashion, so that the circuitous paths of life are detours toward a death of its own choosing. The road film is the genre of that detour. Mike's death-proof seat is an attempt to monopolize the manner of dying: to die in his own fashion, which is to say not at all, while others die in his.

4.5 The Fourfold Crash: Repetition, Delay, and the Relay of the Leg

Mike kills Julia and her friends by driving headlong into their car with his lights off. The collision is replayed from several vantage points, each iteration isolating the destruction of a different victim. Freud described the repetition compulsion as the return of a trauma the psyche cannot master. Laura Mulvey's *Death 24x a Second* (2006) described the "delayed cinema" of the digital age, in which the viewer can pause, slow, and repeat the image, becoming either a possessive spectator who seizes the fetish or a pensive one who contemplates the passage of time. *Death Proof*'s replay performs the delay for the viewer, anticipating the home-video spectator's impulse to rewind. Barthes called the photograph a "flat death" in *Camera Lucida* (1980) and named as *punctum* the unintended detail that pierces the viewer. The crash is a punctum industrialized and iterated—a contradiction, since in Barthes's account the punctum cannot be intended.

In the crash, Jungle Julia's leg is severed. The leg forms a relay across the program: Cherry's leg in *Planet Terror*, Julia's in the first half of *Death Proof*, Abernathy's foot in the second. The leg is the program's circulating partial object, its *objet petit a* in Lacan's sense, and it gathers Tarantino's notorious podophilic iconography; *Death Proof*'s first image is of bare feet on a dashboard. Freud's "Fetishism" (1927) interpreted the fetish as a substitute for the maternal phallus whose absence the fetishist simultaneously acknowledges and disavows. Tarantino's cinema had already linked the foot to resurrection: in *Kill Bill: Volume 2* (2004), the Bride, waking from years of coma, begins her return to life by willing her big toe to move. *Death Proof* completes the figure. Abernathy (Rosario Dawson) dozes with her foot out of the car window, and Mike, passing, caresses it. In the final seconds the same heel delivers the blow on which the film freezes. The fetish strikes the fetishist.

4.6 Relic, Index, and the Ordeal of the Mast

The second group differs from the first in one decisive respect. Kim (Tracie Thoms) and Zoë (Zoë Bell) are stunt performers and cinephiles; they know *Vanishing Point*, *Dirty Mary Crazy Larry* (1974), and *Gone in 60 Seconds*, while Lee (Mary Elizabeth Winstead) and Abernathy do not. Subcultural capital becomes survival competence. Clover attributed to the Final Girl a heightened watchfulness that lets her

perceive the threat her companions ignore; in *Death Proof* the watchfulness is cinephilic, the vigilance of those who know the genre's history.

Zoë's desire is to drive a white 1970 Dodge Challenger, the model Kowalski drove in *Vanishing Point*. The car is a contact relic, an object sanctified by association with the saint of a cult. Kowalski's film ends with his car driven into a roadblock of bulldozers, a death read variously as suicide, martyrdom, and apotheosis. *Death Proof* revises the relic's fate: the Challenger survives and becomes the vehicle of vengeance. The film performs a counterfactual redemption of its source.

To borrow the Challenger, the women leave Lee with its owner as collateral. In Euripides' *Iphigenia at Aulis*, the maiden is offered to Artemis to obtain the winds that will carry the fleet to Troy, and in one strand of the tradition the goddess substitutes a deer and spirits her away. Lee is the sacrifice that buys the voyage, and the film's ellipsis of her fate functions as the substitution: a merciful absence.

The ordeal the women seek is "Ship's Mast," in which Zoë rides the hood of the speeding car, gripping belts fastened to the door frames. The game inverts the twelfth book of the *Odyssey*, in which Odysseus has himself lashed to the mast so that he may hear the Sirens and survive. Here the woman binds herself to the mast to hear the siren of speed, and the predator arrives as the monster of the strait. She is also a figurehead, the carved woman at a ship's prow. Bell had been Uma Thurman's stunt double in *Kill Bill* and Lucy Lawless's in the mythological series *Xena: Warrior Princess*; in *Death Proof* she appears as herself, and the ride was performed at speed. The image documents real risk. Here Bazin's ontology of the photographic image (1945) and Charles Sanders Peirce's index, the sign physically connected to its referent, return to the program with full force. Tarantino's women do not merely represent danger. One of them undergoes it.

The image changes accordingly. The second half passes through a black-and-white interlude that yields to saturated color, and its distress diminishes until the image is nearly clean. This is apocalypse in the etymological sense: *apokalypsis*, unveiling. The counterfeit scars fall away as the real body takes the risk. When Mike rams the Challenger and Zoë is thrown from the hood, her companions search the roadside fearing she is dead; she rises from the brush, laughing. The Lazarus complex, simulated throughout the program by counterfeit decay, is here performed by an indexical body that has actually fallen.

4.7 Sparagmos: Maenads, Erinyes, and the Laughing Medusa

Kim shoots Mike in the arm, and the hunter becomes the hunted. The reversal has two Theban prototypes, both narrated in the third book of Ovid's *Metamorphoses*. Actaeon, who sees Diana bathing, is transformed into a stag and torn apart by his own hounds. Pentheus, who spies on the rites of the maenads, is torn apart by them, and in Euripides' *Bacchae* (405 BCE) his mother Agave returns to the city bearing his head, which she believes to be a lion's. Mike, who

has photographed the women without their knowledge, is a voyeur in the line of Actaeon and Pentheus, and his death is a sparagmos at the hands of maenads.

The *Oresteia* (458 BCE) ends with the Erinyes, the Furies who pursue the matricide Orestes, persuaded by Athena to accept the jurisdiction of the court she founds and to become the Eumenides, the Kindly Ones. Aeschylus' trilogy dramatizes the passage from vendetta to law. *Death Proof* reverses it: McGraw's law has failed, and the Eumenides revert to Erinyes. Walter Benjamin's "Critique of Violence" (1921) distinguished the law-preserving violence that fails here from a law-destroying "divine" violence that strikes without bloodshed. The women's violence is neither. It is bloody, festive, and collective. Nietzsche wrote in *On the Genealogy of Morals* (1887) that without cruelty there is no festival, and *Death Proof*'s ending is a festival.

The final blow freezes and the words "The End" appear. Freud's "Medusa's Head" (1922) interpreted the decapitated Gorgon as an image of castration and the petrification of the beholder as both terror and consolation. The freeze-frame is Medusan: it turns the man to stone. Hélène Cixous's "The Laugh of the Medusa" (1975) urged women to look at the Medusa straight on and see that she is not deadly but beautiful, and laughing. The women of *Death Proof* laugh as they kill.

Clover's Final Girl survives the slasher alone, and Clover showed that she becomes, in the rape-revenge film, the avenger of her own violation. *Death Proof* splits the slasher into its two halves, massacre and revenge, and distributes the Final Girl's function across a collective: the Final Girl pluralized becomes communitas. The film is a rape-revenge narrative without a rape, in which sexual violence is displaced onto the vehicle, as McGraw's diagnosis makes explicit. Its mythic ancestors are Procne and Philomela, the sisters who avenge Tereus's rape and mutilation of Philomela; Judith, who beheads Holofernes, as Artemisia Gentileschi painted her around 1612–13; and the Valkyries, choosers of the slain, riding above the battle as Zoë rides above the road.

4.8 The Gaze, the Fetish, and the Residue of Exploitation

The objection that *Death Proof* merely rehearses the male gaze deserves full weight. Its first half lingers on its women's legs, feet, and buttocks with a fixity Mulvey's theory describes exactly, and its women speak in a cadence recognizably Tarantino's own, so that female speech is ventriloquized by the auteur. The second half answers by redistributing the gaze: the women become subjects of craft, knowledge, and action, and the camera's pleasure shifts from their bodies toward their agency. The cheer that greets their victory belongs to Williams's body genres as surely as tears or arousal: a spectatorial convulsion produced by excess.

René Girard's *Violence and the Sacred* (1972) argued that communities found their unanimity on the death of a sacrificial victim. The revenge of the second half depends on the deaths of the first: the women of Austin, and Pam, are sacrificed so

that the triumph in Tennessee may be legible. The film ritualizes the exploitation of women; it does not abolish it. That residue is not a flaw incidental to *Death Proof*. It is the cost the film's own economy imposes, and Chapter Seven formalizes it.

4.9 *Death Proof* as Proto-Counterfactual

Death Proof inaugurates the counterfactual mode that would define Tarantino's subsequent cinema. In *Inglourious Basterds* (2009), Shosanna Dreyfus burns her cinema with its hoard of highly flammable nitrate film and kills the leadership of the Third Reich: the film burn simulated in *Grindhouse* becomes a weapon that rewrites history. *Django Unchained* (2012) rewrites the history of slavery as revenge western. *Once Upon a Time in Hollywood* (2019) rewrites the Manson murders through the intervention of the stuntman Cliff Booth (Brad Pitt), in a film that casts Kurt Russell as narrator and stunt coordinator, and Zoë Bell as his wife. The stuntman who was a murderer in 2007 becomes a guardian in 2019. *Death Proof* is the hinge between genre counterfactual and historical counterfactual: it first rewrites the outcome of a genre, the slasher, before Tarantino's later films rewrite the outcomes of history. Revenge becomes historiographical method, and cinema claims the power to rescue its victims retroactively.

5

Chapter Five

THE INTERSTITIAL GOSPEL

Counterfeit Trailers as Hrönir

5.1 The Trailer as Rhetoric and Attraction

Lisa Kernan's *Coming Attractions* (2004) analyzed the trailer as a rhetorical form that addresses its audience as consumers of a promised experience, organized around the temporality of the "not yet." Tom Gunning's concept of the "cinema of attractions" (1986), describing the exhibitionist, non-narrative address of early film, finds in the trailer its most durable survival within narrative cinema. Eisenstein's montage of attractions, which drew in part on the onstage mutilations of the Grand Guignol, supplies the trailer's grammar: a sequence of aggressive moments arranged for maximum sensory and emotional effect, unburdened by narrative development.

A counterfeit trailer advertises a commodity that does not exist. It is a promise without a product, and therefore the purest form of desire, which Lacan understood as structured by lack. Its literary precedents are Jorge Luis Borges's reviews and summaries of imaginary books and Stanisław Lem's *A Perfect Vacuum* (1971), a collection of reviews of nonexistent works. The interstitial program of *Grindhouse* is a perfect vacuum of exploitation cinema.

The trailers also compose a map. *Machete* is Mexican and Mexican-American; *Werewolf Women of the SS* is Nazi and German; *Don't* is British; *Thanksgiving* is American and colonial; *Hobo with a Shotgun* is Canadian. Together they form a geopolitical rosary of exploitation's national imaginaries, each nation represented by the violence it most fears or most enjoys.

5.2 *Machete*

Machete stars Danny Trejo, whose face and tattooed torso—the image of a woman in a charro hat across his chest is the most famous of his tattoos—are among the most recognizable in American genre cinema, and whose much-publicized biography of incarceration and redemption lends the fiction an indexical charge. The body is already scarred and inscribed; cicatricial mimesis finds here a performer who does not need to counterfeit it. The trailer presents a former Mexican federal agent turned day laborer who is hired to assassinate a politician, betrayed, and set upon a path of vengeance. Its title names a tool whose history is the history of agrarian labor in the Americas, from the cane fields of the plantation economy to the insurgent machete charges of Cuba's wars of independence. The tool of labor becomes the weapon of revolt.

Positioned at the head of the program, *Machete* opens *Grindhouse* with a Mexican avenger; *Planet Terror* closes with an exodus to Mexico. The first half of the program is bracketed by the border. In 2010, *Machete* was realized as a feature, co-directed by Rodriguez and Ethan Maniquis, amid national controversy over Arizona's immigration law SB 1070, and *Machete Kills* followed in 2013. The fake trailer became a real film, and the parody became a political intervention.

5.3 *Werewolf Women of the SS*

Rob Zombie's trailer pastiches Nazisploitation, the 1970s cycle exemplified by *Ilsa, She Wolf of the SS* (1975), whose art-house counterparts included Pier Paolo Pasolini's *Salò* (1975). Susan Sontag's "Fascinating Fascism" (1975) diagnosed the eroticization of fascist iconography in postwar culture, the transformation of the SS uniform into a costume of sexual theater. Saul Friedländer's *Reflections of Nazism* (1982) identified a new discourse on Nazism organized around the juxtaposition of kitsch and death. *Werewolf Women* is an exemplary instance of both. Its legitimacy as pastiche depends on whether the excess of its absurdity—its lupine transformations, its mad science, Nicolas Cage's cameo as Sax Rohmer's Fu Manchu—neutralizes or exploits the atrocity it borrows. The question admits no comfortable answer, and the trailer's brevity is its only alibi.

The werewolf has a mythic genealogy the trailer activates. In the first book of Ovid's *Metamorphoses*, the tyrant Lycaon tests Jupiter's divinity by serving him human flesh and is transformed into a wolf: the first werewolf is a tyrant who practices cannibal sacrifice. The Nazi regime cultivated its own lupine iconography. Hitler used "Wolf" as a pseudonym, his headquarters bore names such as Wolfsschanze and Werwolf, and the planned guerrilla resistance of 1944–45 was called Werwolf. The trailer literalizes a regime's totemism. Fu Manchu, the Yellow Peril villain Rohmer created in 1913, belongs to the archive of Orientalism Edward Said dissected (1978), and his presence turns the trailer into a museum of pulp villainy, a kitsch cosmology of evil.

5.4 *Don't*

Edgar Wright's *Don't* pastiches the European horror film of the 1970s as American distributors retitled and advertised it, a practice that produced a flood of titles beginning with prohibitions. Its narrator never completes a sentence: every warning breaks off at its first word. The gag reduces horror to its essential grammatical form, the imperative. "Don't" is the voice of the Law, the superego's command, the paternal prohibition Lacan named in the homophony of the *Nom* and the *Non du Père*. Bataille's *Erotism* (1957) argued that prohibition creates the desire for transgression and that eroticism lives in the violation of taboo. Horror's pleasure lives in the violated "don't": the door that is opened, the basement that is entered. Wright's trailer is the shortest possible horror film, a prohibition awaiting its violation. Its British inflection marks the inheritance of the British gothic tradition of Hammer and Amicus, which *Grindhouse* otherwise omits.

5.5 *Thanksgiving*

Eli Roth's *Thanksgiving* pastiches the holiday slasher—*Black Christmas* (1974), *Halloween* (1978), *My Bloody Valentine* (1981), *Silent Night, Deadly Night* (1984)—

with a killer in Pilgrim costume who stalks a New England town. The choice of holiday is not innocent. Thanksgiving commemorates the founding myth of English settlement, and the historiography of colonial days of thanksgiving has long been contested in relation to the violence of settlement against Indigenous peoples. Robin Wood's theory of the American horror film (1979) located its monsters in the return of what normality represses; *Thanksgiving*'s Pilgrim is the return of the national founding's repressed violence. Freud's *Totem and Taboo* (1913) proposed that the totem meal commemorates a primal murder, the killing and devouring of the father by the brothers who then institute law; Girard's founding murder makes the same claim in another vocabulary. The national feast is a totem meal, and *Thanksgiving* restores the murder to the feast.

The trailer's gags of sexualized mutilation are calculated outrages, but the director of *Hostel* here practices not the forensic suffering of torture porn but the carnival grotesque, in which outrage is a joke and the wound a fountain. The trailer, too, became a feature, released in 2023.

5.6 *Hobo with a Shotgun* and the Liturgical Apparatus

Jason Eisener's *Hobo with a Shotgun*, winner of a trailer contest tied to the release, played with *Grindhouse* in some Canadian theaters and was realized as a feature in 2011, starring Rutger Hauer, whose role in *The Hitcher* (1986) had made him an icon of the highway psychopath. Its vagrant avenger completes the trailers' gallery of the dispossessed: the day laborer, the transformed woman, the homeless man. The contest that produced it completed the democratization of the guild.

The program's remaining apparatus—the "Our Feature Presentation" bumpers, the rating cards, and an advertisement for the Acuña Boys Tex-Mex restaurant—functions as liturgy. The restaurant's name inscribes Ciudad Acuña, where *El Mariachi* was shot, into the intermission: Rodriguez embeds his origin in the program's commercial interval. The intermission is a threshold in Victor Turner's sense (1969), a liminal passage between two states. The program's structure resembles that of the Mass, in which a liturgy of readings precedes a liturgy of sacrifice; it resembles more closely the medieval mystery cycles, such as that of York, in which each craft guild staged its own pageant on a wagon in the streets. In the York Crucifixion pageant, assigned to the guild of pinners, the soldiers grumble about the difficulty of their labor as they nail Christ to the cross, treating the execution as a job of work. Violence as craft, staged by a guild of craftsmen: the pageant is the remote ancestor both of the stunt performer's ethic and of the guild that made the trailers.

5.7 Hrönir: The Fakes That Became Real

In Borges's "Tlön, Uqbar, Orbis Tertius" (1940), a fictitious world invented by a learned society gradually intrudes upon reality, and its *hrönir*—duplicate objects produced by expectation—begin to appear in the world. The counterfeit trailers of *Grindhouse* are *hrönir*. At least three—*Machete*, *Hobo with a Shotgun*, and *Thanksgiving*—subsequently engendered features. Jean Baudrillard's *Simulacra and Simulation* (1981) argued that in the age of simulation the map precedes the territory. *Grindhouse* realized that claim with unusual literalness: its advertisements for nonexistent films produced the films they advertised.

Borges's "Pierre Menard, Author of the Quixote" (1939) describes a twentieth-century writer who sets out to compose, word for word, chapters of *Don Quixote*, and argues that the identical text means something entirely different when written in a different century. *Grindhouse* is Menardian. It composes the exploitation film of the 1970s anew in 2007, and the result, however close in style, is a different text: an elegy where the original was an entertainment, a theory where the original was a practice.

6

Chapter Six

A COMPARATIVE MORPHOLOGY OF THE WOUNDED IMAGE

Propp's *Morphology of the Folktale* (1928) reduced the Russian wondertale to thirty-one functions recurring in fixed sequence; Lévi-Strauss's "The Structural Study of Myth" (1955) sought the mytheme, the smallest unit of mythic relation. This chapter isolates five mythemes that organize *Grindhouse* and traces each across mythology, literature, and horror. The table maps the correspondences; the sections that follow interpret them.

Mytheme	In *Grindhouse*	Mythic and literary analogues	Horror analogues
Sparagmos: dismemberment and re-membering	Cherry's leg; Jungle Julia's leg; Abby's jar; the missing reels; the severed release	Osiris; Dionysus Zagreus; Pentheus; Coyolxauhqui; Ymir; Tiamat; Frankenstein's creature	*Freaks* (1932); *The Texas Chain Saw Massacre* (1974); *Braindead* (1992)
The empowering wound	The gun-leg; the table leg; Dakota's numbed hands; Mike's scar	Philoctetes; Nuada of the Silver Arm; Týr; Odin; Jacob at the Jabbok; Odysseus' scar	*Rolling Thunder* (1977); *Videodrome* (1983); *Evil Dead II* (1987); *RoboCop* (1987)
The psychopomp-driver	Stuntman Mike; the death-proof car	Charon; Hades' chariot; the Wild Hunt; the pale horse of Revelation 6:8	*Duel* (1971); *The Car* (1977); *Christine* (1983); *Crash* (1996)
The avenging collective	The women of Tennessee; the commune at Tulum	Erinyes; maenads; Procne and Philomela; Judith; Valkyries	*Thriller – A Cruel Picture* (1973); *I Spit on Your Grave* (1978); *Ms. 45* (1981)
Descent, return, renewal	Cherry and Pam; Zoë's fall and rise; dawn at Tulum	Persephone; Inanna; Lazarus; Ragnarök's green earth; the woman clothed with the sun	*Night of the Living Dead* (1968); *Deathdream* (1974); *Kill Bill: Volume 2* (2004)

6.1 Sparagmos and Cosmogony

The mythologies of dismemberment divide into two families. In the first, dismemberment is cosmogonic: the world is made from a body cut apart. The Babylonian *Enuma Elish* tells how Marduk splits the body of Tiamat to form heaven and earth; Snorri's *Gylfaginning* tells how Odin and his brothers kill the giant Ymir and fashion the earth from his flesh, the sea from his blood, and the sky from his skull; the Purusha hymn of the Rig Veda (10.90) derives the cosmos and its social order from the sacrifice of a primordial man. In the second family, dismemberment is soteriological: a god is torn apart and reassembled, and the reassembly founds a cult. Osiris, Dionysus Zagreus, and, in another key, Coyolxauhqui belong here. *Grindhouse* participates in both. *Planet Terror*'s dismembered bodies found a new world at Tulum, and the program's own dismemberment—by missing reels and by the severance of its release—founded the cult in which it now survives.

Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein* (1818) is the modern myth of the assembled body, and in her introduction to the revised edition of 1831 she bade the novel go forth as her "hideous progeny." *Grindhouse* is a hideous progeny of the same kind: stitched together from the parts of dead films, animated by the electricity of a new medium, and abandoned by the industry that made it.

6.2 The Empowering Wound

The wound that confers power or identity is among the most widespread figures in world mythology. Jacob wrestles through the night with a stranger at the ford of the Jabbok, is struck in the hollow of the thigh, and limps away with a new name, Israel (Genesis 32). Týr loses his hand in the jaws of the wolf Fenrir so that the gods may bind the beast; Odin gives an eye at Mímir's well in exchange for wisdom. Hephaestus, the lame smith of the gods, forges automata and the armor of heroes. In each case the loss of a part purchases a power or a name. The horror tradition weaponizes the wound: the hook of *Rolling Thunder*, Ash's chainsaw, Max Renn's flesh-pistol in *Videodrome*, which carries Cronenberg's slogan of the "new flesh."

Franz Kafka's "In the Penal Colony" (1919) gives the mytheme its most terrible modern form. An apparatus inscribes the condemned man's sentence on his body with needles, and the inscription is meant to bring him understanding at the sixth hour; when the officer who reveres the machine submits himself to it, it breaks down and kills him without revelation. The body becomes the page on which the law writes, as the film body of *Grindhouse* becomes the page on which its counterfeit history is scratched. Kafka's apparatus is cicatricial mimesis as punishment; *Grindhouse* is the same apparatus turned to the uses of devotion.

6.3 The Psychopomp-Driver

The psychopomp conducts the dead. Charon ferries them across the Styx; Hades carries Persephone down in his chariot; in the folklore of northern Europe the Wild Hunt rides through the winter sky gathering souls. The Book of Revelation gives the image its most famous English form: "behold a pale horse: and his name that sat on him was Death, and Hell followed with him" (Revelation 6:8). The automobile inherits the chariot's office in modern horror. Steven Spielberg's *Duel* (1971) pits a motorist against a truck whose driver is never seen; Elliot Silverstein's *The Car* (1977) makes a driverless vehicle a demon; Carpenter's *Christine* (1983), from Stephen King's novel, makes the car a jealous lover; Paul Bartel's *Death Race 2000* (1975) makes vehicular homicide a national sport. Ballard's *Crash* makes the collision a sacrament. Stuntman Mike is the psychopomp of this tradition, rider of the pale horse, god of the highways of the dead.

Those highways belong to Clive Barker, whose "The Book of Blood" (1984), the frame story of his *Books of Blood*, is itself a parable of cicatricial mimesis. A fraud-

ulent medium who has faked communications with the dead is seized by the dead themselves, who carve their stories into his skin, so that the fake becomes, through wounding, an authentic book of the dead. *Grindhouse* is a counterfeit medium of this kind, on whose surface the forgotten films of exploitation inscribe their histories.

6.4 The Avenging Collective

The avenging women of myth are rarely solitary. The Erinyes pursue in packs; the maenads move as a *thiasos*; Procne and Philomela act together, and their revenge on Tereus, in the sixth book of Ovid's *Metamorphoses*, takes the form of a cannibal feast in which the rapist is served his son. Shakespeare's *Titus Andronicus* (c. 1592) rewrites Ovid's tale: Lavinia, raped and mutilated, her tongue and hands cut away, reveals her attackers by turning the pages of Ovid's book to the story of Philomela, and her father avenges her by baking her rapists into a pie served to their mother. The Elizabethan revenge tragedy, from Thomas Kyd's *The Spanish Tragedy* (c. 1587) onward and descended from Seneca's *Thyestes*, was the grindhouse of its age, a popular theater of blood.

Its descendants in exploitation cinema are the rape-revenge films Clover analyzed: Bo Arne Vibenius's *Thriller – A Cruel Picture* (1973), Meir Zarchi's *I Spit on Your Grave* (1978), Abel Ferrara's *Ms. 45* (1981), and Wes Craven's *The Last House on the Left* (1972), itself a remake of Ingmar Bergman's *The Virgin Spring* (1960), which derives from a medieval Swedish ballad. The lineage thus runs unbroken from ballad to art film to grindhouse. *Death Proof* takes its place in it while altering its numerology: its avenger is a collective, its violation is displaced, and its feast is the joyous beating that ends the film.

6.5 Descent, Return, Renewal

The descent to the underworld and the return from it structure the oldest narratives of renewal. In the Sumerian *Descent of Inanna*, the goddess passes through seven gates, surrendering an ornament at each, is killed and hung on a hook, and is revived, leaving a substitute in her place. Persephone's annual descent and return order the seasons. Lazarus, dead four days, is called from the tomb (John 11). *Grindhouse* stages descent and return at every level: Cherry rises as Pam falls; Zoë falls from the car and rises from the brush; Earl McGraw dies in one film and walks in the next; the program itself dies at the box office and returns on home video. Romero's *Night of the Living Dead* made the return of the dead a political allegory; Bob Clark's *Deathdream* made it the return of the war; Tarantino's *Kill Bill: Volume 2*, in which the Bride, buried alive, breaks her coffin and claws her way out of the grave, made it the return of the avenger. The program's final word is not death but return: the dawn at Tulum, and the next screening of the grind.

6.6 The Theater of Blood before Cinema

The genealogy of *Grindhouse* extends beyond cinema into the popular theaters and print cultures of blood. The Théâtre du Grand-Guignol in Paris, active from 1897 to 1962, specialized in short naturalistic plays of mutilation and murder, many written by André de Lorde, and supplied Eisenstein with a paradigm of the attraction. The penny dreadful *The String of Pearls* (1846–47) introduced Sweeney Todd, the barber whose victims are baked into pies, extending the line that runs from the Thyestean banquet to the barbecue of *The Texas Chain Saw Massacre*.

In Mexico, the broadsides printed by Antonio Vanegas Arroyo and illustrated by José Guadalupe Posada (1852–1913) brought murders, disasters, and miracles to a mass public in cheap sheets whose skeletal *calaveras* satirized every class. Posada's calaveras, including the figure later known as La Catrina, are the Mexican grindhouse of print, and the skull painted on the hood of Mike's first car belongs to their visual family. Octavio Paz wrote in *The Labyrinth of Solitude* (1950) of a Mexican intimacy with death, which the culture mocks, courts, and celebrates in the fiesta. *Planet Terror*, which ends in Mexico, is closer to that fiesta than to the American apocalypse.

7

Chapter Seven

TOWARD A THEORY OF CICATRICIAL MIMESIS

7.1 Definition and Differentiation

Cicatricial mimesis is the representational regime in which an image manufactures upon itself the scars of a history it did not undergo. Three features constitute it. First, it inscribes a counterfeit history in the form of damage rather than style: it imitates not the look of a period but the wounds of an object's passage through time. Second, it makes a claim of membership: like Odysseus' scar before Eurycleia, the counterfeit damage solicits recognition, asking the viewer to acknowledge the image as a returning survivor of a community of the wounded. Third, it is sacrificial: the image surrenders its integrity—its clarity, continuity, and completeness—as the price of meaning.

The concept must be distinguished from its neighbors. It differs from Jameson's pastiche because the scar is not depthless: it is depth expressed as surface, the closed trace of an event, and it refers to a wound rather than to a style. It differs from Dyer's affective pastiche because its mode is not empathy but sacrifice. It differs from parody, which Linda Hutcheon defined as repetition with critical distance (1985), because its relation to its source is not distance but wounded proximity. It differs from Baudrillard's simulacrum because it does not copy an object without an original but simulates the history of an object's loss: it is the simulacrum of a wound. More precisely, it reintroduces into the third order of simulation, the order of the code, the logic of Baudrillard's first order, the counterfeit—the craft of the forger who distresses an object to give it age. It differs from hauntology, which Derrida introduced in *Specters of Marx* (1993) and Mark Fisher developed through the audible crackle of recorded music (2014), because what it mourns is not a lost future but a lost congregation. And it differs from remediation, Jay David Bolter and Richard Grusin's account of new media refashioning old ones (1999), because what it remediates is not the old medium's capacities but its entropy.

The concept's closest ancestor is Auerbach's *Mimesis*, whose first chapter opposes two styles through two scenes. The Homeric style, exemplified by Odysseus' scar, externalizes everything and leaves nothing in shadow. The Elohist style, exemplified by the binding of Isaac in Genesis 22, leaves nearly everything unsaid, so that the narrative is fraught with background. Auerbach's founding figures are a scar and a sacrifice. *Grindhouse* fuses them. Its counterfeit damage is Homeric, a history written entirely on the surface; its missing reels are Elohist, gaps in which the decisive events occur unseen. The burned frame that precedes each missing reel joins the two: it is the scar of the gap. Cicatricial mimesis is a third style, in which scar and sacrifice become a single figure.

Walter Benjamin defined aura as the unique appearance of a distance, however near the object may be, and argued that technical reproducibility dissolves it. Cicatricial mimesis manufactures a synthetic aura by inscribing temporal distance on the surface of the reproduction. Benjamin also wrote, in his study of

the German *Trauerspiel* (1928), that allegories are in the realm of thought what ruins are in the realm of things. *Grindhouse* is a pre-ruined artifact, built with its ruin already installed, like the sham ruins of eighteenth-century landscape gardens or Hubert Robert's imagined view of the Louvre's Grand Gallery in ruins (1796). Georg Simmel's essay "The Ruin" (1911) described ruin as nature's revenge upon the forms spirit imposes; the counterfeit ruin is spirit's revenge upon its own perfection.

7.2 From the Mummy Complex to the Lazarus Complex

André Bazin's "The Ontology of the Photographic Image" (1945) traced the plastic arts to a "mummy complex," the desire to preserve the body against the flow of time by embalming it in representation; photography, in his account, embalms time itself, and Philip Rosen's *Change Mummified* (2001) took its title from Bazin's formula. *Grindhouse* inverts the complex. Its image does not wish to be preserved; it wishes to be seen to decay. Its model is not the mummy but Lazarus. When Jesus orders the stone removed from the tomb of his friend, Martha objects that the body has been dead four days and stinks (John 11:39). The stench is the precondition of the miracle's legibility: a resurrection without decay would be mere resuscitation. A digital revival of 1970s exploitation in pristine form would be a remake; counterfeit decay makes it a resurrection, the return of something that has passed through death. The image must be seen to rot before it can be raised. This is the *Lazarus complex*.

The complex has a biological counterpart in thanatosis, the death-feigning by which animals—the opossum is the proverbial case—survive predators by appearing dead. The image of *Grindhouse* plays dead in order to live. It has a professional counterpart in the stunt performer, who feigns injury and death for a living. And it has narrative counterparts throughout the program: the sickos, who simulate putrefaction in bodies that will not die; Earl McGraw, who dies in one film and returns in the next; Zoë Bell, presumed dead on the roadside and rising, laughing, from the brush; and behind them the Bride of *Kill Bill: Volume 2*, clawing her way out of the grave.

Paleobiology supplies a test for every claim of return. A "Lazarus taxon" is a lineage that vanishes from the fossil record and later reappears, having survived unrecorded. An "Elvis taxon," in the coinage of Douglas H. Erwin and Mary L. Droser (1993), is a later lineage that resembles an extinct one through convergence, an impersonator mistaken for a survivor. Every revival must answer whether it is Lazarus or Elvis. Kurt Russell played Elvis Presley in 1979; in *Death Proof* he plays a 1970s stuntman in 2007, an Elvis taxon of heroic masculinity. *Grindhouse* knows that it is an Elvis taxon, a convergent impersonation of exploitation cinema produced with a budget no exploitation film ever had. It performs a Lazarus

nonetheless. Its claim to the lineage is not genealogical but sacrificial: it earns its descent by wounding itself, constructing a self-inflicted pedigree.

Ernst Kantorowicz's *The King's Two Bodies* (1957) reconstructed the medieval and Tudor doctrine by which the king possessed a mortal body natural and an immortal body politic, so that the death of the one did not interrupt the continuity of the other. A film, too, has two bodies: the material print, which wears, tears, burns, and dies, and the work, which persists across its copies. Photochemical cinema joined the two, since every screening wounded the print a little more. Digital cinema threatened to abolish the body natural, leaving an incorruptible body politic that could not die and therefore could neither be resurrected nor become sovereign in the cultic sense. *Grindhouse* grafts a counterfeit body natural onto the digital body politic, so that the film can die and its death can found its afterlife. The old acclamation returns in a new form: the print is dead; long live the film.

7.3 The Four Bodies and the Law of Conserved Damage

Grindhouse distributes injury among four bodies. The filmic body comprises emulsion, reel, and print, with their scratches, burns, color shifts, and missing reels. The feminine body comprises the women of both features, from Cherry and Dakota to Pam, Butterfly, Jungle Julia, Zoë, Kim, and Abernathy. The sovereign-masculine body comprises the men who claim the power to dispose of life—Muldoon, Block, Abby, Tarantino's soldier, Stuntman Mike—together with the hero-king El Wray. The communal body comprises the collectives the films assemble and the audience the program addresses: the Tulum commune, the women of Tennessee, and the congregation of the grind.

The Law of Conserved Damage holds that across the program injury is neither created nor destroyed but redistributed among these four bodies, so that the healing of one coincides with the wounding of another. The law is heuristic rather than quantitative. It formalizes a structural tendency in the manner of Freud's economic model of the psyche, with its conserved quantities of excitation, and of Bataille's general economy, in which a surplus that cannot be accumulated must be spent. Its compact statement is that, for any transition between segments of the program, the changes in damage across the four bodies sum to zero:

The Law of Conserved Damage

$$\Delta D_{\text{film}} + \Delta D_{\text{women}} + \Delta D_{\text{sovereign}} + \Delta D_{\text{community}} = 0$$

Segment	Filmic body	Feminine body	Sovereign-masculine body	Communal body
Planet Terror: siege and infection	Heavy distress throughout	Cherry amputated; Dakota numbed	Muldoon, Block, Abby, Tarantino's soldier decompose	Provisional siege group forms
Planet Terror: missing reel	Frame burns; reel lost	Consummation withheld; child conceived offscreen	El Wray's past withheld	Not yet constituted
Planet Terror: Tulum	Distress persists	Cherry re-membered as armed mother	El Wray dead; military sovereign destroyed	Commune founded at dawn
Death Proof: Austin	Heavy distress; dance withheld	Pam and the women of Austin killed	Mike immune, lightly injured, unpunished	Law fails; no community forms
Death Proof: Tennessee	Image cleansed; black-and-white yields to color	Zoë falls and rises; the women survive	Mike shot, beaten, killed	Avenging collective forms
Release and afterlife	Program severed into separate features	Heroines circulate apart	Directors' potlatch ends in loss	Multiplex congregation fails; cult re-forms at home

The table makes the law's transfers visible. In *Death Proof*'s second half, the cleansing of the image coincides with the destruction of the sovereign-masculine body and the formation of the avenging collective: the filmic body heals as the man is wounded and the community is born. In *Planet Terror*, the dismemberment of the feminine body and the decomposition of the sovereign-masculine body together purchase the foundation of the commune. After the release, the failure of the multiplex congregation coincides with the industrial dismemberment of the filmic body.

The law's political meaning is that damage is never abolished, only redistributed. The exploitation cinema of the 1970s concentrated its damage on the feminine body; *Grindhouse* redistributes it toward the sovereign-masculine and filmic bodies, and in this sense practices a distributive justice of wounds. But the law also exposes the program's limit, which is Girard's. If the quantity of damage is conserved, sacrifice is ineliminable, and someone—Pam, Butterfly, Julia, Lee—must still pay.

7.4 The Double Apocalypse

The two features stage two senses of the word apocalypse. *Planet Terror*'s is catastrophic: the end of a world, collective in scale, cyclical in structure, culminating

in renewal on a Mesoamerican and Norse model, and produced on digital video. *Death Proof*'s is revelatory: an unveiling, individual and then collective in scale, linear in structure, culminating in the disclosure of a real body at risk, and produced on 35mm film. The first is the apocalypse of simulation; the second, the apocalypse of the index. Their opposition is not a hierarchy. *Planet Terror*'s digital catastrophe achieves the communal renewal that *Death Proof*'s revelation alone cannot provide, and *Death Proof*'s revelation supplies the indexical truth the digital catastrophe lacks. The diptych needs both halves.

Frost's poem supplies the structural key. Its last line is spoken twice, first literally and then metaphysically. Søren Kierkegaard's *Repetition* (1843) distinguished recollection, which repeats backward, from repetition proper, which recollects forward; Gilles Deleuze's *Difference and Repetition* (1968) made difference the inner truth of every repetition. *Grindhouse* repeats its own line—a woman, a road, a wound, a missing reel—and the second statement transforms the first. The two features share a world but not a reconciled chronology, since figures such as Dakota Block and Earl McGraw pass between them without either film troubling to order their histories. The program is less a sequence than a band joined at its ends, as the grind's continuous screenings made it in practice.

In the ninth of his theses "On the Concept of History" (1940), Benjamin described the angel of history, who faces the past and sees a single catastrophe piling wreckage at his feet. The angel would like to stay, awaken the dead, and make whole what has been smashed, but a storm blowing from paradise, which we call progress, drives him irresistibly into the future. *Grindhouse* is the angel's attempt. It faces the wreckage of exploitation cinema and tries to make whole what has been smashed, while the storm of digital progress drives it forward. The attempt failed commercially and succeeded cultically, which is the only success available to the angel.

7.5 The Vanishing Point

Leon Battista Alberti's *De pictura* (1435) organized the perspectival picture around a centric point at which parallel lines appear to converge, and Erwin Panofsky's *Perspective as Symbolic Form* (1927) read that point as the image's internal infinity, where a homogeneous, mathematized space meets the unrepresentable. The missing reels of *Grindhouse* are its vanishing point. In both features, the reel that disappears is the reel of erotic consummation: the lovemaking of Cherry and El Wray, the lap dance of Butterfly. In both, the film resumes in violence. The lines of eros converge at the vanishing point and reemerge as lines of death. Bataille defined eroticism as assenting to life up to the point of death and argued that eroticism and death alike restore the continuity that individual existence interrupts. The missing reel is where that assent takes place, offscreen.

Death Proof names the structure through its canonized source: *Vanishing Point* ends where Kowalski's road and the bulldozers meet. The missing reel is the program's vanishing point in Alberti's sense and in Sarafian's. It is also its sanctuary. Psyche may not see her lover; the Incarnation occurs under an overshadowing; Pseudo-Dionysius, in *The Mystical Theology*, taught that the divine is approached through a darkness beyond knowledge. The sacred center of *Grindhouse* is apophatic: it is what the program refuses to show.

Sontag concluded "Against Interpretation" (1964) by demanding that an erotics of art replace hermeneutics. *Grindhouse* answers her with a paradox. Its erotics has been cut out—literally, as missing reels—and the cut compels interpretation. A work whose erotic center is withheld produces interpreters as a wound produces scar tissue. The present dissertation is, in this precise sense, a symptom of its object.

7.6 Immunity, Communitas, and the Lost Congregation

Esposito's paired concepts organize the program's politics. *Planet Terror* depicts the immunitary paradigm in autoimmune collapse; *Death Proof* depicts immunity privatized as the exemption of a single sovereign driver. Each answers with a communitas formed not by shared identity but by shared exposure. Jean-Luc Nancy's *The Inoperative Community* (1983) described community as the compearance of finite beings exposed to one another in their mortality, and Maurice Blanchot's *The Unavowable Community* (1983) and Alphonso Lingis's *The Community of Those Who Have Nothing in Common* (1994) extended the thought. The Tulum commune of the amputated, the numbed, and the orphaned, and the women of Tennessee, bound by a risk they choose together, are such communities. *Freaks* stands behind the first, with its fellowship of the marked.

The ultimate community the program addresses is its audience. Émile Durkheim located the origin of religion in the collective effervescence of assembled groups (1912); Turner distinguished the obligatory liminality of ritual from the voluntary "liminoid" experiences of modern leisure (1974). The grindhouse was a liminoid congregation, and Delany's "contact" names its sociality. *Grindhouse* is addressed to that congregation, which no longer exists: the audience of 42nd Street was displaced by the redevelopment that produced the corporate entertainment architecture in which *Grindhouse* was released. The program's ideal spectator is dead. Its failure at the box office was the failure of a rite addressed to a vanished congregation, and its communitas could be reconstituted only privately, in homes, on discs: a congregation of the isolated.

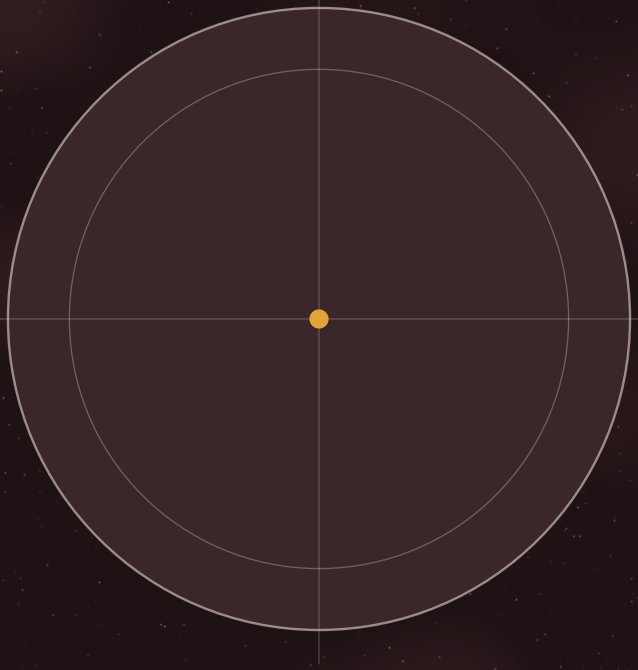
7.7 Objections and Limits

Four objections must be met. The first is Sandmel's: the analogies proposed here are parallelomaniac. The answer lies in the criteria stated in the Introduction. Each analogy has been anchored in a specific feature of the text—the name "Butterfly," the casting of Rose McGowan in both features, the setting at Tulum, the fate of the missing reels in the extended cuts, the Challenger of *Vanishing Point*—and where no such anchor exists, the analogy has been offered as structural rather than genetic.

The second objection is Sontag's: interpretation impoverishes the sensuous work. The answer, already given, is that the work's own excision of its erotic center makes interpretation its consequence rather than its betrayal.

The third objection is political and the most serious. *Grindhouse* commodifies the marginal spectatorship it mourns. The working-class, Black, Latino, and queer audiences Delany describes were displaced by the redevelopment whose architecture housed the film, and the film converts their culture into premium entertainment for an affluent cinephile public. In this light *Grindhouse* is gentrified grind, and the critique stands. Cicatricial mimesis does not exempt its practitioners from the economy that produced the wounds they counterfeit.

The fourth objection concerns gender, disability, and coloniality. The program's redistribution of damage does not abolish the exploitation of women; its prosthetic heroine is also a narrative prosthesis; its Mexican utopia reenacts, in inversion, the fantasy of Mexico as an available refuge. The Law of Conserved Damage is descriptive, not exculpatory. It explains why the program cannot escape these residues: a system that conserves damage cannot eliminate it.



Conclusion

MILES TO GO

The argument of this dissertation can be compressed into a single proposition: *Grindhouse* teaches that an image, like a person, enters community by being wounded. Its counterfeit scars claim kinship with the wounded films of exploitation and with the wounded audiences that loved them; its dismemberments, diegetic and industrial, reenact the oldest myths of the torn and reassembled god; its two features stage the end of a world and the unveiling of the real; its missing reels conceal, at its center, the convergence of eros and death; and its economy of injury conserves damage even as it redistributes it. What criticism has called pastiche is better understood as liturgy, and what it has called nostalgia is better understood as mourning that knows the dead may be raised only after they have been seen to decay.

The program's afterlives have confirmed its theory. Its counterfeit trailers became features, as the *hrönir* of Tlön became objects. Tarantino's *Inglourious Basterds* turned the film burn into a weapon, igniting nitrate to destroy the Reich; his *Once Upon a Time in Hollywood* turned the murderous stuntman into a guardian, gave Kurt Russell the narrator's voice, and placed Zoë Bell within the stunt community the film elegizes. His *Cinema Speculation* (2022), an account of the 1970s spectatorship *Grindhouse* had mourned, is the auteur's own square-up, the prefatory lecture delivered fifteen years after the feature. Within a few years of the release, the visual culture of the smartphone democratized cicatricial mimesis. Applications such as Hipstamatic (2009) and Instagram (2010) offered filters that aged every photograph at the instant of its taking, and Nathan Jurgenson diagnosed the result in 2011 as the "faux-vintage photo," a nostalgia for the present. The Lazarus complex has become a general condition of digital culture. Every image may now wear the scars of a history it never had, and every self may now present itself as a survivor of a past it did not live.

The work's philosophy is therefore larger than its genre. It holds that integrity is purchased by injury; that the sacred lies in what is missing; that immunity is a crime and exposure a bond; that damage, like energy, changes form but does not disappear; that the dead have highways, and the living have miles to go. Frost's traveler stops by the woods, is tempted by their darkness, and continues on his way. The double feature stops by the woods of a dead cinema, enters them, is cut, burned, and dismembered there, and comes out on the other side bearing scars that are, in the end, the only proof it can offer that it went.

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Howard Hawks, 1959

THE TINGLER
William Castle, 1959

HOUSE ON HAUNTED HILL
William Castle, 1959

À BOUT DE SOUFFLE
Jean-Luc Godard, 1960

THE VIRGIN SPRING
Ingmar Bergman, 1960

BLOOD FEAST
Herschell Gordon Lewis, 1963

BANDE À PART
Jean-Luc Godard, 1964

FASTER, PUSSYCAT! KILL! KILL!
Russ Meyer, 1965

NIGHT OF THE LIVING DEAD
George A. Romero, 1968

DUEL
Steven Spielberg, 1971

SHAFT
Gordon Parks, 1971

SWEET SWEETBACK'S BAADASSSSS SONG
Melvin Van Peebles, 1971

VANISHING POINT
Richard C. Sarafian, 1971

THE LAST HOUSE ON THE LEFT
Wes Craven, 1972

COFFY
Jack Hill, 1973

THE CRAZIES
George A. Romero, 1973

ENTER THE DRAGON
Robert Clouse, 1973

THRILLER – A CRUEL PICTURE
Bo Arne Vibenius, 1973

BLACK CHRISTMAS
Bob Clark, 1974

DEATHDREAM
Bob Clark, 1974

DIRTY MARY CRAZY LARRY
John Hough, 1974

FOXY BROWN
Jack Hill, 1974

GONE IN 60 SECONDS
H. B. Halicki, 1974

THE TEXAS CHAIN SAW MASSACRE
Tobe Hooper, 1974

DEATH RACE 2000
Paul Bartel, 1975

ILSA, SHE WOLF OF THE SS
Don Edmonds, 1975

JAWS
Steven Spielberg, 1975

SALÒ, OR THE 120 DAYS OF SODOM
Pier Paolo Pasolini, 1975

SATÁNICO PANDEMONIUM
Gilberto Martínez Solares, 1975

SHIVERS
David Cronenberg, 1975

SWITCHBLADE SISTERS
Jack Hill, 1975

ASSAULT ON PRECINCT 13
John Carpenter, 1976

THE CAR
Elliot Silverstein, 1977

RABID
David Cronenberg, 1977

ROLLING THUNDER
John Flynn, 1977

HALLOWEEN
John Carpenter, 1978

HOOPER
Hal Needham, 1978

I SPIT ON YOUR GRAVE
Meir Zarchi, 1978

ELVIS
John Carpenter, 1979; television

THE STUNT MAN
Richard Rush, 1980

ESCAPE FROM NEW YORK
John Carpenter, 1981

MS. 45
Abel Ferrara, 1981

MY BLOODY VALENTINE
George Mihalka, 1981

THE THING
John Carpenter, 1982

CHRISTINE
John Carpenter, 1983

VIDEODROME
David Cronenberg, 1983

SILENT NIGHT, DEADLY NIGHT
Charles E. Sellier Jr., 1984

THE RETURN OF THE LIVING DEAD
Dan O'Bannon, 1985

BIG TROUBLE IN LITTLE CHINA
John Carpenter, 1986

THE HITCHER
Robert Harmon, 1986

EVIL DEAD II
Sam Raimi, 1987

ROBOCOP
Paul Verhoeven, 1987

BRAINDEAD
Peter Jackson, 1992

EL MARIACHI
Robert Rodriguez, 1992

RESERVOIR DOGS
Quentin Tarantino, 1992

CHUNGKING EXPRESS
Wong Kar-wai, 1994

PULP FICTION
Quentin Tarantino, 1994

FOUR ROOMS
Allison Anders, Alexandre Rockwell, Robert Rodriguez, and Quentin Tarantino, 1995

XENA: WARRIOR PRINCESS
television, 1995–2001

CRASH
David Cronenberg, 1996

FROM DUSK TILL DAWN
Robert Rodriguez, 1996

28 DAYS LATER
Danny Boyle, 2002

KILL BILL: VOLUME 1
Quentin Tarantino, 2003

KILL BILL: VOLUME 2
Quentin Tarantino, 2004

SAW
James Wan, 2004

HOSTEL
Eli Roth, 2005

SIN CITY
Robert Rodriguez and Frank Miller, with Quentin Tarantino as special guest director, 2005

CHILDREN OF MEN
Alfonso Cuarón, 2006

PAN'S LABYRINTH
Guillermo del Toro, 2006

GRINDHOUSE
Robert Rodriguez and Quentin Tarantino, 2007
comprising Planet Terror *(Rodriguez)*, Death Proof *(Tarantino), and the trailers* Machete *(Rodriguez)*, Werewolf Women of the SS *(Rob Zombie)*, Don't *(Edgar Wright)*, Thanksgiving *(Eli Roth), and, in Canadian exhibition,* Hobo with a Shotgun *(Jason Eisener)*

INGLOURIOUS BASTERDS
Quentin Tarantino, 2009

MACHETE
Robert Rodriguez and Ethan Maniquis, 2010

HOBO WITH A SHOTGUN
Jason Eisener, 2011

DJANGO UNCHAINED
Quentin Tarantino, 2012

MACHETE KILLS
Robert Rodriguez, 2013

ONCE UPON A TIME IN HOLLYWOOD
Quentin Tarantino, 2019

THANKSGIVING
Eli Roth, 2023

Keywords

GRINDHOUSE ◆ ROBERT RODRIGUEZ ◆ QUENTIN TARANTINO ◆
PLANET TERROR ◆ *DEATH PROOF* ◆ EXPLOITATION CINEMA ◆
DOUBLE FEATURE ◆ CICATRICIAL MIMESIS ◆
LAZARUS COMPLEX ◆ THANATOSIS ◆ THANATOMIMESIS ◆
SPARAGMOS ◆ PROSTHESIS ◆ NARRATIVE PROSTHESIS ◆
DISABILITY STUDIES ◆ PHARMAKON ◆ AUTOIMMUNITY ◆
IMMUNITAS ◆ COMMUNITAS ◆ STATE OF EXCEPTION ◆
NECROPOLITICS ◆ APOCALYPSE ◆ INDEXICALITY ◆
DIGITAL ONTOLOGY ◆ PHOTOCHEMICAL FILM ◆
COUNTERFEIT RUIN ◆ SYNTHETIC AURA ◆ HAUNTOLOGY ◆
PASTICHE ◆ PARACINEMA ◆ CINEPHILIA ◆ CULT CINEMA ◆
COUNTERFEIT TRAILER ◆ HRÖNIR ◆ RAPE-REVENGE ◆
FINAL GIRL ◆ MALE GAZE ◆ ABJECTION ◆
THE GROTESQUE ◆ POTLATCH ◆ COYOLXAUHQUI ◆
COATLICUE ◆ CHICANA FEMINISM ◆ BORDERLANDS ◆
MESOAMERICAN MYTHOLOGY ◆ PERSEPHONE ◆ PSYCHE ◆
PENTHEUS ◆ MEDUSA ◆ NEMI ◆ POLITICAL THEOLOGY ◆
THE KING'S TWO BODIES ◆ MISSING REEL ◆
VANISHING POINT ◆ LAW OF CONSERVED DAMAGE


THE
END